The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called The Irreversible Wheel

Āryāvaivartacakranāmamahāyānasūtra · Toh 240 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་ཕྱོགས་མི་ལྡོག་པའི་འཁོར་ལོ་ཞེས་བྱ་བ་ཐེག་པ་ཆེན་པོའི་མདོ

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra called The Irreversible Wheel, known in Sanskrit as the Āryāvaivartacakra and in Tibetan as Phakpa Chir Mi Dokpé Khorlo, is a Mahāyāna sūtra preserved as Toh 240 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the General Sūtra section. It opens at Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, where the Buddha, the youthful Mañjuśrī, and the bodhisattva Maitreya each enter deep meditative absorption in the last watch of the night, setting the scene for a teaching that gathers disciples such as Śāriputra and Ānanda. The discourse concerns irreversibility on the path to awakening, the state from which a practitioner can no longer turn back, and it presents its teaching as the Irreversible Wheel of great wisdom. In its closing section the Buddha explains how faith in this teaching completes all six perfections and shortens one's time in cyclic existence, before the assembly rejoices amid wondrous signs. According to its colophon, it was translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra, Dānaśīla, and Munivarma together with the Tibetan editor-translator Yeshé Dé.

In the language of India: aryā vaivarta cakra nāma mahāyāna sūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra called "The Irreversible Wheel." The first section.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One (the Buddha) was staying at Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove of Prince Jeta, the park of Anāthapiṇḍada, together with a great saṅgha of monks.

Then, in the last watch of the night, the Blessed One entered into the meditative absorption called Stainless Light. Mañjuśrī, the youthful, entered into the meditative absorption called All-Illuminating. The bodhisattva great being Maitreya entered into the meditative absorption called Universal Light.

Then, in the last watch of the night, at daybreak, the venerable Śāriputra came out of his dwelling and went to where the dwelling of Mañjuśrī the youthful was. As the venerable Śāriputra thought to enter the dwelling of Mañjuśrī the youthful, he saw ten thousand lotuses rising up all around the Blessed One's residence, and he also heard a great sound of song. He saw that light came

forth from those lotuses as well. He saw that the light lit up the whole of the Jeta Grove of Prince Jeta. He saw that the entire great city of Śrāvastī and the whole of the great trichiliocosm, the world system of a billion worlds, became illuminated as well.

Then, as the venerable Śāriputra was thinking that he would not go into the dwelling of Mañjuśrī the youthful, he found that he had entered it, and knew that he himself was sitting in front of Mañjuśrī the youthful. He saw Mañjuśrī the youthful sitting with his legs crossed. Seeing him, he snapped his fingers, but Mañjuśrī did not rise. Then he cleared his throat, but still Mañjuśrī did not rise. Then, having seen the miraculous display of Mañjuśrī the youthful, he felt as though he were dwelling in the midst of the great ocean, and he saw Mañjuśrī the youthful, seated with his legs crossed, travelling eastward together with the dwelling.

Then the venerable Śāriputra sat cross-legged in front of Mañjuśrī the youthful, gazing at Mañjuśrī the youthful without blinking, and he saw Mañjuśrī the youthful pass eastward beyond as many world systems as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges, and arrive at a world system called the Realm of Irreversibility.

Then he saw the tathāgata called Body of a Fully Blossomed Lotus Covered with Rays of Light. He saw lotuses come forth from the pores of that tathāgata, and those lotuses filled ten thousand leagues. He saw that those lotuses were in full bloom, each with a thousand petals. He saw, seated on the centers of those lotuses, bodhisattvas endowed with the thirty-two major marks, their bodies the color of gold. Among them was one great lotus that had become empty, the Blessed One having risen from it. He saw Mañjuśrī the youthful sit upon that great lotus and rise up into the sky together with it; having risen up, circumambulate that Blessed One three times; bow his head at the feet of that Blessed One; and then sit cross-legged on that same great lotus.

Then the tathāgata Body of a Fully Blossomed Lotus Covered with Rays of Light, although he knew, said this to Mañjuśrī the youthful: "Mañjuśrī the youthful, where have you just come from?"

When he had said this, Mañjuśrī the youthful said this to the tathāgata Body of a Fully Blossomed Lotus Covered with Rays of Light: "Blessed One, I have come from the Sahā world system."

Then that Blessed One's attendant, the bodhisattva called Sweet Sound, rose from his lotus seat, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, bowed his head

at the feet of that Blessed One, placed his right knee on the center of the lotus, bowed toward the Blessed One with his palms joined, and said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how far away is that Sahā world system?"

When he had asked this, the tathāgata Body of a Fully Blossomed Lotus Covered with Rays of Light said this to the bodhisattva great being Sweet Sound: "Son of noble family, it lies to the west of this world system, beyond as many world systems as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges."

He asked, "Blessed One, which blessed one teaches the Dharma in that world system?"

That Blessed One said, "He is called the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni."

He asked, "Blessed One, what kind of Dharma does he teach?"

He said, "He teaches on the basis of three vehicles."

He asked, "Blessed One, what are those three vehicles?"

He said, "The vehicle of the śrāvakas, the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas, and the Great Vehicle. It is on the basis of those three vehicles that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni teaches the Dharma."

He asked, "Blessed One, are not the Dharma teachings of all the buddhas, the blessed ones, in agreement?"

He said, "Son of noble family, the Dharma teachings of the buddhas, the blessed ones, are in agreement."

He asked, "To what extent are the Dharma teachings of the buddhas, the blessed ones, in agreement?"

He said, "The Dharma teachings of the buddhas, the blessed ones, agree in the irreversible wheel of Dharma."

He asked, "Blessed One, why then does that Blessed One teach the Dharma on the basis of three vehicles?"

He said, "Son of noble family, those beings are inclined toward what is lesser. Because they do not enter the one vehicle, he guides them in that way through skill in means. Son of noble family, the buddhas, the blessed ones, possess great skill in means. That Blessed One has appeared in a time of the five degenerations, and those beings have no faith in the one vehicle."

He asked, "Blessed One, is it really so hard to teach the Dharma there?"

He said, "Son of noble family, it is so."

He asked, "Blessed One, it is truly my good fortune that I was not born there."

He said, "Son of noble family, do not say that."

He asked, "Blessed One, why is that?"

He said, "Son of noble family, compared with someone who accomplishes roots of virtue here for twenty thousand years, someone there accomplishes far more merit in a single morning. And why? Because that world system is so utterly afflicted."

He asked, "Blessed One, how utterly afflicted has that world system become?"

He said, "Son of noble family, as for how utterly afflicted that world system has become: were you to listen to the utter affliction of that world system, your whole lifespan would run out."

Then the bodhisattva great being Sweet Sound took lotuses made of the seven precious substances and scattered them in the direction of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni. Having scattered them, he said again and again, "I shall behold that Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha."

He said, "Son of noble family, do you wish to see that Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha?"

He replied, "Blessed One, I wish to see him."

He said, "Then go together with this Mañjuśrī the youthful."

Then the bodhisattva Sweet Sound said this to Mañjuśrī the youthful: "Mañjuśrī, I shall go to behold that Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha."

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of noble family, for the moment there are many buddhas, blessed ones, to whom I must pay homage and offer veneration."

He said, "Then I too shall pay homage and offer veneration together with you."

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful paid homage to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Body of a Fully Blossomed Lotus Covered with Rays of Light and circumambulated him three times. Then, in the time it takes a strong man to stretch out his bent arm or bend his outstretched arm, Mañjuśrī

the youthful vanished from that world system, and he appeared in the presence of the buddhas, the blessed ones, in as many world systems to the east as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges, and in every one of them this very Dharma teaching was taking place. So it was too in the south, the west, the north, the zenith, the nadir and the intermediate directions. Yet here in the Sahā world system, in Jambudvīpa, night had not yet given way to dawn.

Then the venerable Ānanda, while still sitting in his dwelling, saw light coming in through the gaps of the window. Thinking that he would go out of his dwelling, he rose from his seat, and he saw that before the sun had risen the whole of the Jeta Grove of Prince Jeta had become illuminated. He saw that the whole of the Jeta Grove of Prince Jeta was filled with clear, limpid, blue water, and that there were neither trees nor temples there. Seeing this, he thought, "Since these portents, which have never occurred before, are appearing, a great Dharma will surely be taught today."

Then the venerable Ānanda thought, "I shall set my foot on the ground." When the venerable Ānanda then set his foot on the ground, it was not wet, nor was it affected in any way, and joy and happiness arose in him. He went to where the Blessed One's residence was, and on arriving he saw ten thousand lotuses all around the Blessed One's residence, and he heard a great sound of music and a great sound of song. He saw that light came forth from those lotuses as well, and he saw that this light illuminated the whole of the great trichiliocosm, the world system of a billion worlds. Joy and gladness arose in him, and he placed his right knee on the ground, joined his palms, and paid homage to the Blessed One. As he paid homage, night turned to dawn and the sun rose.

From among those lotuses, one went to the center of the Jeta Grove of Prince Jeta and remained there. Then the venerable Ānanda saw that lotus remaining in the center of the Jeta Grove of Prince Jeta. Then the venerable Ānanda thought, "Portents of a Dharma teaching have occurred. I shall go and prepare the Blessed One's seat." As soon as the Blessed One's seat was prepared, the great earth quaked in six ways. The whole of the Jeta Grove of Prince Jeta was covered all over with flowers. Trees laden with flowers and with fruit appeared as well.

All the monks too thought to come out of their dwellings, but seeing the whole of the Jeta Grove of Prince Jeta filled with clear, blue water, they were able neither to go out nor to turn back. They saw no trees or temples there, but they saw a great radiance. While still remaining in those very dwellings, they

thought, "Since these portents are appearing, a great Dharma will surely be taught today."

Then the Blessed One arose from that meditative absorption and sat down on the seat that had been prepared. As soon as the Blessed One was seated, Mañjuśrī the youthful emerged from the depths of the earth together with countless tens of millions of bodhisattvas. Having emerged, he bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and sat down before the Blessed One together with those bodhisattva great beings.

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, go, and summon all the monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen, however many are staying in Prince Jeta's Grove in Śrāvastī."

"Excellent, Blessed One," replied the venerable Ānanda, and heeding the Blessed One, he went about from monastery to monastery and said to the monks, "Venerable ones, the Teacher is calling you."

They replied, "We too have recognized the portents, yet we are unable to go. Why? Because we see that the whole of Prince Jeta's Grove is filled with clear blue water."

Then the venerable Ānanda, having heard what those monks said, went to where the Blessed One was, bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, and said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, the monks are not able to come. Why? Because they see that the whole of Prince Jeta's Grove is brimming with clear blue water."

The Blessed One declared, "Ānanda, those monks perceive as water what is not water. Just as those monks perceive as water what is not water, in the same way they perceive as the fruit of stream-entry what is not the fruit of stream-entry; they perceive as the fruit of once-returning what is not the fruit of once-returning; they perceive as the fruit of non-returning what is not the fruit of non-returning; they perceive as the fruit of arhatship what is not the fruit of arhatship; they perceive as a pratyekabuddha what is not pratyekabuddhahood; they perceive as form what is not form; and so with what is not feeling, what is not perception, what is not formations, and what is not consciousness, they perceive it as consciousness. Ānanda, go and summon them, and they will come."

Then the venerable Ānanda, heeding the Blessed One, entered the great city of Śrāvastī in order to summon those monks once more, and he announced to the monks, the nuns, the laymen, and the laywomen, "Venerable ones, the Teacher is calling you."

Then the venerable Ānanda, having announced this to the four assemblies, went to where the Blessed One was, bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, and said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, I have announced it to the four assemblies."

Then the Blessed One declared to the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana, "Maudgalyāyana, go, and summon all who are present in the great trichiliocosm, the world system of a billion worlds: the bodhisattva great beings who have donned the great armor, and the monks, nuns, laymen, laywomen, gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, and nonhumans, however many there are."

"Excellent, Blessed One," replied the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana, and heeding the Blessed One, in an instant, a moment, a split second, just as a strong man might stretch out his bent arm or bend his outstretched arm, Mahāmaudgalyāyana announced it throughout the great trichiliocosm to the bodhisattva great beings, the monks, the nuns, the laymen, the laywomen, the gods, the nāgas, the yakṣas, the gandharvas, the asuras, the garuḍas, the kinnaras, the mahoragas, the humans, and the nonhumans. Then, through the might of the Buddha and the power of his own miraculous abilities, he sat down before the Blessed One and said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, I have announced it to the four assemblies."

Then those four assemblies came to fill an area a thousand leagues (yojanas) in circumference, and the gods filled the sky above to a height of some fifty thousand leagues.

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, now that these four assemblies have gathered, and the gods too have filled the sky, may the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, please teach the Dharma concerning the Irreversible Wheel. Blessed One, in this assembly there are many monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen, and many hundreds of thousands of gods. Since there are many others besides who perceive the fruit of stream-entry, who perceive the fruit of once-returning, who perceive the fruit of non-returning, who perceive the fruit of arhatship, and who perceive pratyekabuddhahood, then in order to free

them from their perceptions, may the Blessed One please explain with what intention the Blessed One taught the fruit of stream-entry, the fruit of once-returning, the fruit of non-returning, and the fruit of arhatship, and with what intention the Blessed One taught pratyekabuddhahood."

Then the Blessed One gave his consent by remaining silent. Then the venerable Śāriputra said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, last night, in the latter part of the night, I rose, came out of my dwelling, and went to where the dwelling of Mañjuśrī the youthful was. When I had arrived there and was about to enter the dwelling of Mañjuśrī the youthful, I saw the Blessed One's residence, and all around the Blessed One's residence I saw ten thousand lotuses. I heard a great sound of music and a great sound of song. I also saw light coming forth from those lotuses, and I saw that light come to pervade the whole of Prince Jeta's Grove, the whole city of Śrāvastī, and the entire great trichiliocosm. Blessed One, of what is this a portent?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke these words to the venerable Śāriputra: "Śāriputra, this is the portent of the teaching of this Dharma, which Mañjuśrī has urged me to give."

Then the venerable Ānanda said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, last night, during the last watch of the night, while I was inside my dwelling, I saw light coming in through the gaps of the window. Thinking, 'I shall go out of my dwelling,' I rose from my seat. Before the sun had risen, the whole of Prince Jeta's Grove had become pervaded by it, and the whole of Prince Jeta's Grove was brimming with clear blue water. I saw that no one was going in here, and that there was no monastery to be seen either. Blessed One, of what is this a portent?"

The Blessed One declared, "Ānanda, this is the portent of the teaching of this untainted Dharma, which Mañjuśrī the youthful has urged me to give."

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Ānanda in verse:

"Fearless Mañjughoṣa
has asked about this:
this wisdom is untainted,
the unsurpassed wisdom of the buddhas.

Fearless Mañjughoṣa,
endowed with wisdom, has asked about it:
this wisdom is free of concepts,

free of elaboration, and free of defilement.

In it no thing is established,
and likewise nothing is unestablished.
The wisdom that has abandoned everything
is what Mañjuśrī has fully asked about.

In it no fruit is established;
it is declared absent in every way.
This is the protector of the worlds,
the veiled speech of the saviors,

for whose sake fearless Mañjughoṣa
has fully asked.
In it there is no sound;
all sounds have become equal."

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what is this? Is Mañjuśrī the youthful making his request for the sake of the Irreversible Wheel?"

He declared, "Ānanda, it is so. Ānanda, the buddhas, the blessed ones, are those who turn the Irreversible Wheel."

Ānanda asked, "Blessed One, with what intention did the Tathāgata teach the follower by faith, and teach the follower of the Dharma? Likewise, with what intention did the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, teach the eighth-ranked one, the stream-enterer, the once-returner, the non-returner, the śrāvaka arhat, and the pratyekabuddha? When the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, with some intention, fully taught the follower by faith, and likewise, with some intention, fully taught the follower of the Dharma, the eighth-ranked one, the stream-enterer, the once-returner, the non-returner, the śrāvaka arhat, and the pratyekabuddha, did the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, thereby fully teach that these too are the very Dharma of the bodhisattva? What is the case? Please, Blessed One, explain it."

He declared, "Ānanda, it is so. The Tathāgata fully taught in this way that these very things are the Dharma of the bodhisattva. Why is that? Ānanda, the beings born in the time of the five degenerations are inclined toward the lesser. Since they are not inclined toward the wisdom of the buddhas, Ānanda, the buddhas, the blessed ones, who are skilled in means, teach the Dharma to

them in that way through skill in means. Ānanda, the beings who are inclined toward the vast are few. Ānanda, it is for the sake of those beings who are inclined toward the lesser that the Tathāgata teaches the Dharma through such skill in means. By this means he teaches the Dharma of the Buddha."

Then the Blessed One, having spoken thus, fell silent.

Then the venerable Ānanda said this to Mañjuśrī the youthful: "Mañjuśrī, why does the Tathāgata let this pass in silence?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Venerable Ānanda, the beings who are inclined toward a teaching of the Dharma such as this are few. These arhats who have the thought, 'I am an arhat,' are very many. Venerable Ānanda, the beings who fully understand what the Tathāgata said with an intention, that is, with what intention the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha taught the Dharma, are few. To me this is directly evident. Those four assemblies have fallen into doubt, wondering how it is that the Tathāgata now establishes the follower by faith, and likewise, at length, up to how he establishes the pratyekabuddha. Because these many tens of millions of bodhisattvas have been pondering with what intention the Tathāgata fully taught the follower by faith, and so on up to with what intention the Tathāgata fully taught the pratyekabuddha, all the waters have been held back and do not flow, and the birds too do not fly in the sky.

Why is that? This teaching of the Dharma is hard to be inclined toward, and so the Tathāgata lets it pass in silence."

Then those ten thousand lotuses moved all around the residence of the Tathāgata, and from them came forth a sound such as this: "Since we have heard this teaching of the Dharma, in this very place, from ninety-nine koṭīniyutas of buddhas, make this request of the Tathāgata: 'Please, may the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, teach the Dharma concerning the teaching of the Dharma of the Irreversible Wheel.'"

Then the venerable Śāriputra made this request to the Blessed One: "Last night, during the last watch of the night, together with Mañjuśrī the youthful, I heard this very teaching of the Dharma from countless buddhas, blessed ones, in the east, and likewise I heard this very teaching of the Dharma from countless buddhas, blessed ones, in the south, the west, the north, below, above, and in the intermediate directions. Therefore, Blessed One, please explain the teaching of the Dharma of the Irreversible Wheel."

Then eighty-five koṭīniyutas of gods dwelling in the sky made this request to the Tathāgata: "Since we have heard this teaching of the Dharma, in this very place, from ninety-two koṭīniyutas of buddhas, may the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, please explain the teaching of the Dharma of the Irreversible Wheel."

Then the venerable Ānanda said this to the Blessed One: "May the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, please teach with what intention the Tathāgata fully taught the follower by faith, fully taught the follower of the Dharma, and likewise, at length, fully taught the eighth-ranked one, the stream-enterer, the once-returner, the non-returner, the śrāvaka arhat, and the pratyekabuddha. Blessed One, these four assemblies remain silent, not even making the sound of clearing their throats, and, Blessed One, many hundreds of thousands of living beings have fallen into doubt and uncertainty. Please dispel the doubt of those who wonder with what intention the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha fully taught the follower by faith, and likewise, at length, up to the pratyekabuddha. These many have become witnesses."

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, it is so. The Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha teaches the Dharma with witnesses."

Ānanda asked, "Blessed One, what is the witness of the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas?"

The Blessed One declared, "Ānanda, the witness of the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas is the Dharma. The tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas possess the power of the Dharma, and they teach those dharmas just as they have directly realized them. Therefore, Ānanda, listen well and closely, and keep it properly in mind, and I shall explain to you how the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha fully taught the bodhisattva great being as a follower by faith, and likewise as a follower of the Dharma, as the eighth-ranked one, as a stream-enterer, as a once-returner, as a non-returner, as a śrāvaka arhat, and as a pratyekabuddha."

"Excellent, Blessed One," replied the venerable Ānanda, and as he listened to the Blessed One, the Blessed One spoke these words: "Ānanda, here a bodhisattva great being has faith in order to lead countless, immeasurable beings to see the Buddha without attachment, and yet does not regard even those qualities of the Buddha as real. He is not attached to form, and likewise

he is not attached to feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness. This, Ānanda, is called a bodhisattva great being who is a follower by faith.

"Moreover, Ānanda, if a bodhisattva great being has conviction that all these dharmas were declared empty by the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, then, Ānanda, a bodhisattva great being so inclined is called a follower by faith.

"Moreover, Ānanda, if a bodhisattva great being has conviction in the wisdom of the Buddha and gives rise to longing for it, thinking, 'When shall I come to possess wisdom such as this?', yet does not regard even that wisdom as real, then, Ānanda, that bodhisattva great being obtains the name 'follower by faith.'

"Moreover, Ānanda, if a bodhisattva great being has no faith in the five qualities of sensual pleasure, and attains the generation of the power of faith, then, Ānanda, that bodhisattva great being should be known as a follower by faith.

"Again, if he thinks, 'Oh, that I might someday become one who gives the inconceivable gift of the Dharma, just as the Tathāgata has given it,' and has conviction in that inconceivable gift of the Dharma, then, Ānanda, that bodhisattva great being too is called a follower by faith.

"Moreover, Ānanda, a bodhisattva great being, with an undaunted mind, gives away completely all that is to be given. Though he gives away even his body, he does not think that he is purified by giving, and he is without avarice toward anything at all. He dedicates all of it to awakening, and yet does not regard even that awakening as real. Such not regarding as real is called a follower by faith.

"Moreover, Ānanda, the bodhisattva great being is perfect in faith in the Buddha. His mind is untainted. He has conviction in the untainted Dharma. He does not reject the six sense sources, nor does he pursue them. He is inclined through faith. Those beings who lack faith he introduces to faith, and he causes them to have faith in the Dharma of the Buddha. Having come to possess faith, he gives rise to the mind set on awakening, and yet he does not find that mind. Having faith, he knows sameness, and he knows the dharmadhātu, the expanse of phenomena, as sameness. How does he know it? It is spoken of conventionally as 'the dharmadhātu,' yet he does not find that expanse either. He has conviction that all formations are impermanent, that all formations are suffering, that all formations are empty, and that all

formations are without anything belonging to a self, and in that too he attains the generation of power. He has conviction in the discipline of the noble ones. He also enters into equipoise in the samādhi free of elaboration. He has conviction in the expanse of cessation, holding that all beings are equal in the expanse of cessation. He regards the faith through which he has conviction as nothing but its characteristic, and he is not attached. Being unattached, he regards all beings as within the dharmadhātu, and yet he does not regard even that dharmadhātu as real. Why is that? The dharmadhātu itself is the expanse in which all beings are without mind. He has conviction in this way, and he has conviction that mind too is just as those dharmas are. Such a one is called a follower by faith.

"Moreover, Ānanda, the bodhisattva great being has conviction that in reality all beings do not abide anywhere. Since all beings are empty of intrinsic nature, he does not regard their abode as real either, and he does not regard all beings as being in the expanse of nirvāṇa. A bodhisattva great being with faith such as this is called a follower by faith."

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

"In the unattached seeing of the Buddha,
he brings immeasurable beings to faith,
yet he has no attachment to it;
therefore the wise one follows by faith.

He has conviction too that all these dharmas
have been declared to be empty.
This is his inclination,
and so he is held to be a follower by faith.

He has conviction in the wisdom of the Sugata,
and thinking, 'When shall I have knowledge like this?'
he turns his longing toward it,
yet he does not see that knowledge either.

In the five qualities of sensual pleasure
he never places his faith;
he attains the power of faith,
and so he is called a follower by faith.

Thinking, 'When shall I give
this inconceivable gift of the Dharma,

just as the Blessed One has given it?'
he is therefore called a follower by faith.

Out of faith toward those who ask,
he gives away everything, even his body;
in giving he has no perception of giving;
therefore the steadfast one follows by faith.

Through faith he gives away everything,
and has no avarice toward anything;
he directs all of it toward awakening,
yet he does not see that awakening either.

Made clear by faith in the perfect Buddha,
his mind is untainted;
he teaches the Dharma of no-mind;
therefore he is called a follower by faith.

Those beings who lack faith
he introduces to faith,
and he causes them to have faith in the stainless Dharma;
therefore he is called a follower by faith.

Having come to possess a mind of faith,
he sets his mind on awakening,
yet he does not find that mind;
therefore the steadfast one follows by faith.

Through faith he knows the dharmadhātu
as ever equal, as sameness itself;
he does not find that expanse,
nor does he apply the convention 'expanse.'

He has conviction that all formations
are impermanent, suffering, empty, and without self,
and by this he generates power;
therefore he is called a follower by faith.

He has conviction in undefiled discipline;
untainted and free of elaboration,
he rests in equipoise in the peaceful expanse;
therefore the wise one follows by faith.

He has conviction that all beings are without an expanse,
and in the expanse of nirvāṇa.
The faith by which he has conviction,
that faith too is but its characteristic.

Being unattached to the dharmadhātu,
he does not see even the realm of beings;
the one endowed with wisdom does not see
the inconceivable dharmadhātu.

The fearless bodhisattva
has conviction through faith
that this Dharma is just as it is;
therefore he is called one endowed with faith.

In reality all beings
are empty of essential nature;
they do not abide anywhere;
there is no abode for them.

All beings have passed into nirvāṇa;
in reality that too is empty;
therefore that nirvāṇa
is proclaimed to be emptiness.

The fearless bodhisattva,
exalted, has conviction in this way;
therefore those of renown
obtain the name 'follower by faith.'

The faith of the followers by faith
is declared to be like this.
Ānanda, retain it in this way,
and teach it in this way.

Ānanda, by these qualities,
and by many others without end,
by those qualities the wise one
is shown to be a follower by faith.

"Ānanda, in this way the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha fully taught the bodhisattva great being as a follower by faith, and through skill in means he leads them to that meaning."

The second fascicle.

"Ānanda, how did the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha fully teach the bodhisattva great being as a follower of the Dharma? Ānanda, here the bodhisattva great being does not turn back from the qualities of the Buddha. He upholds the qualities of the Buddha and teaches them. He does not stray from that expanse, and he attains the inconceivable dharmas. Holding them in reverence, he upholds them, and his mind is undaunted. He teaches the stream of the Dharma that is the very essence of the Dharma, and he clings to nothing whatsoever. Indeed, without attachment to dharmas or to what are not dharmas, he teaches the nature of reality, which is unabiding and without support. He desires the Dharma; he does not desire what is not the Dharma. He upholds all dharmas in the manner of not grasping, and having upheld them, he teaches them. He is gentle, and it is a joy to keep his company.

He teaches the peaceful Dharma, and he neither stirs the dharmadhātu nor clings to it. He understands all dharmas to be without characteristics, and he does not stray from that nature of reality. Why is that? He abides well in the body in the manner of not abiding. How does he abide well? He abides well in this way: 'This body is forever not a body.' Through the nature of the body, he makes equal what is neither beginning nor end. He knows that nature of reality as neither taking up nor carrying off. He also attains the Dharma that the buddhas, the blessed ones, have taught to the bodhisattvas. Being unattached to all dharmas, he is stainless, and yet he does not see purity either. The dharmas he does not see he does not grasp at all, and this dharmadhātu is taught to be without affliction, signless, without intrinsic nature, without activity, without entity, free of mind, and mindless. That in which mind is not observed is called mindless, without attainment, and fully pacified. It is without convention, free of convention, and without object. Though he upholds it, because the nature of reality is without entity, he does not abide anywhere, and it is through that nature of reality that he has opened it up.

"This nature of reality is in truth taught to the bodhisattva: in it there is no mixing, no scattering, and no obstruction. This account of it is unchanging, and since it is attained just as it is described, it is called the ground of the lineage. Because he attains it, it is fully taught as the ground of the lineage. That bodhisattva great being attains this ground of the lineage as well. He does not regard even the subtlest dharma as coming or going, and he upholds all

dharmas, which neither come nor go, without stirring them. He does not scatter them, he does not gather them, and he upholds the Dharma that is without scattering and without grasping. Therefore he is called a follower of the Dharma. Because he attains the nature of reality, and because there is no attainment of any dharma, he is called a follower of the Dharma."

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

"In every way, with regard to the Buddha's Dharma,
he does not turn back from the Dharma,
and he upholds these natures of reality;
therefore he is called a follower of the Dharma.

The inconceivable stream of the Dharma:
he does not stray from that stream;
he attains that nature of reality;
therefore he is called a follower of the Dharma.

The Dharma that the buddhas have taught
he upholds with reverence;
his mind is undaunted;
therefore he is called a follower of the Dharma.

The stream of the Dharma by its very essence,
that stream he fully teaches;
he has no clinging to dharmas;
therefore know him as a follower of the Dharma.

The stream of the Dharma, unabiding
and without support, he truly realizes;
he upholds that nature of reality;
therefore the wise one follows the Dharma.

The nature of the bodhisattva
that the buddhas have taught,
that nature of reality he attains;
therefore the wise one follows the Dharma.

The expanse is empty of essential nature,
without fixity in any dharma;
he upholds that nature of reality;
therefore the wise one follows the Dharma.

Having examined all dharmas as empty,
he sees no fault in them;
the dharmas he has not come to see,
those he does not grasp.

This expanse, the dharmadhātu,
is without affliction and without signs,
and is taught to be without essential nature;
it is inexpressible and without entity.

This expanse is free of mind;
that mind cannot be observed.
Since mind is not observed,
it is therefore called inconceivable.

Without thought and without attainment,
what is called fully pacified
is inexpressible and without object;
therefore it is called inconceivable.

He upholds these natures of reality,
yet he does not abide anywhere;
being without entity, he does not abide;
therefore he is called a follower of the Dharma.

To that bodhisattva
this nature of reality is taught:
unmixed and not set in place,
unchanging and luminous.

That from which the lineage is proclaimed
is the domain of the noble ones;
because he has fully heard it,
it is called the ground of the lineage.

The irreproachable bodhisattva,
in harmony with this lineage,
upholds it in this way;
therefore he is called a follower of the Dharma.

Because he has fully attained the nature of reality,
he is held to be a follower of the Dharma.
Ānanda, it is with this in mind

that I have spoken of the bodhisattva

as a 'follower of the Dharma';
I explained this with an intention.
Those who think awakening far away,
I lead them near in this way.

Thus I have explained
many qualities of the bodhisattva,
and by means such as this
I teach the qualities of the Buddha."

"Ānanda, in this way the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha fully taught the bodhisattva great being as a follower of the Dharma.

"Ānanda, how did the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha fully teach the bodhisattva great being as the eighth-ranked one? Ānanda, here the bodhisattva great being has completely transcended the eight wrong states. He has touched the eight liberations, and yet he has no clinging even to the eight right states. He has completely transcended the qualities of ordinary beings. He abides well on the path, having attained the intermediate state. He has gone beyond the qualities of ordinary beings and has actually entered the vehicle of the Buddha, yet he does not find that awakening. He has completely transcended wrong view, and he has also demolished right view. He has attained sameness and has passed beyond the transitory collection. He has actually entered upon awakening and has attained the path of the Buddha. He has reversed the perception of beings. He has demolished the perception of buddhas. He has attained the sameness of perception. He has completely transcended the abode of beings. He has actually entered the unabiding, and he does not abide in any dharma. Why is that? Because the dharmas that would become his abode are not observed.

He has completely transcended worldly dharmas, has entered the supramundane dharmas, and has attained the sameness of the element of cessation and the dharma element. He does not observe worldly dharmas or supramundane dharmas, and he has completely abandoned dharmas and non-dharmas, existence and nonexistence. He perceives annihilation and permanence as equal, and he has become equal toward past, future, and present mind. He does not observe even the awakening mind. Why is that? Because he knows all beings as equal, as sameness. Therefore poison, fire,

and weapons cannot harm his body. Why is that? Because he has completely abandoned all objects, and his realization abides well in the domain of the buddhas. Why is that? Awakening has no going and no coming; it is bliss, it is peace, it is beyond enumeration; and he abides well in that meditative absorption. Why is that? Awakening is empty. Thus he has no abode, and so weapons do not touch or strike his body. That is why he is called "one who cannot be slain."

Such renunciation is what cannot be slain, and through it he realizes, in bliss, the knowledge of bliss. Why is that? Because he does not find even the knowledge by which he realizes. So weapons cannot harm or strike his body. Why is that? Because he knows all dharmas as unmixed. Therefore he cannot be slain by weapons. Why is that? Because he pervades all beings with loving-kindness: with the loving-kindness that accomplishes the aspects of awakening; with the loving-kindness that is without aspects and without attachment; with the loving-kindness that has not attained the emptiness of all dharmas and the element of peace; with the loving-kindness that has abandoned malice and covetousness; with the loving-kindness sent forth by the superknowledges and by wisdom; with the loving-kindness that has attained the light of awakening; and with the loving-kindness that does not observe beings. With that loving-kindness he pervades all beings, and therefore he cannot be slain by weapons.

Through the sameness of the dharma element he knows the desire realm, the form realm, and the formless realm as sameness. The bodhisattva, the great being, enters the sameness of the dharma element in this way: awakening is unchanging, not to be cognized by consciousness, free of conceptual thought, free of conceptual elaboration, and free of turbidity. In whatever is expressed in sound, all of it, he comes to understand realization and non-realization, non-realization of the dharma element, and realization without abiding, and so he is skilled in all sounds. He teaches a Dharma that has no definitive words, and he has no conceit that thinks, "I am teaching some dharma." He is free of perception, and he enters the sameness of all sounds. He is not separated from any dharma, and he knows them as empty and at peace. He does not observe any dharma that he would need to pass beyond; therefore he is called "the eighth." Because he is not attached to any dharma, he is called "the eighth."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses:

He has wholly transcended the eight wrong ways,
He has touched the eight liberations,
He has no clinging to the eight right ways;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

He has passed beyond the dharmas of ordinary beings,
And abides very well upon the path;
Possessed of wisdom, he sees no middle;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

He has passed beyond the state of an ordinary being,
And has actually entered upon awakening,
Yet he does not observe that awakening;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

He has completely transcended wrong view,
And has demolished right view;
He attains the sameness of the excellent path;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

He has completely passed beyond the transitory collection,
And has fully entered supreme awakening;
He has also attained the path of the Buddha;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

He has reversed the perception of self,
And demolished the perception of awakening;
He has attained the perception that is beyond compare;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

He has wholly transcended the abode of beings,
And has fully entered the unabiding;
He does not abide in any dharma at all;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

He has completely transcended worldly dharmas,
And demolished the dharmas of the noble ones;
He has attained the element of cessation;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

Whatever is spoken of as worldly dharmas,
And whatever dharmas of the Buddha are held distinct,
Those dharmas he does not find;

Therefore he is called "the eighth."

To say "it exists" is one extreme;
To say "it does not exist" is the second;
These extremes he has completely abandoned;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

For him self and selflessness are equal,
Permanence and annihilation are equal;
He knows sameness to be equal;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

He does not find the past mind,
And so too with the future mind;
He has attained sameness with the present;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

The first mind set on awakening,
Whatever virtue has arisen:
If that mind is not observed,
How does he attain awakening?

The one for whom awakening is not observed
Has entered thus into non-observation;
Therefore poison and fire
Cannot harm him in any way.

He is free of going;
He has no attachment to signs;
He has reached the going that has no going;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

Awakening is free of going;
It is fully expressed in words,
Yet he has demolished even sound;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

In it no going is found,
In it no non-going is found;
The sounds "not going" and "going"
Are taught as wisdom, as peace.

That peace is said to be bliss;
Peace is said to be emptiness;
Because he has attained the element of peace,
He is said to be one who cannot be slain.

That intelligent one, in bliss,
Thus realizes the knowledge of bliss;
He has not given up anything at all;
Therefore he is held to be one who cannot be slain.

Even sharp weapons, well released,
Do not strike his body,
For he has no perception of a body as a body;
Therefore he cannot be slain by weapons.

Therefore, with the loving-kindness of awakening,
With loving-kindness he pervades all beings;
The intelligent one has abandoned malice;
Therefore he cannot be slain by weapons.

He has cleared away ignorance and bad perception,
And has let go of knowledge and perception too;
For the sake of awakening he has attained the light;
Therefore he cannot be slain by weapons.

He regards even weapons as empty,
And has demolished the perception of a body;
He has attained the path of awakening;
Therefore he cannot be slain by weapons.

He has attained the element of peace,
He has completely abandoned all the lower realms,
He has passed beyond the karma of wrongdoing;
Therefore he cannot be slain by weapons.

The desire realm and the form realm,
And the formless realm too, in every way:
He knows the three realms as the same;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

Awakening, the sameness of the dharma element,
Is unchanging and cannot be shown,
Is not an object of knowledge, is free of conceptual thought,

Free of elaboration and free of turbidity.
The irreproachable bodhisattva
Enters sameness in this way.

Whatever is expressed in sound,
In it one does not go by going.
He who fully explains the dharmas
Is skilled in all languages,
Yet he has no conceit at all
That thinks, "I have explained something."
He has wholly passed beyond all sounds
And realizes the soundless nature of reality;
Therefore he is called "the eighth."

In all sounds there is nothing definite.
Ānanda, it is with this in mind
That I have spoken of "the eighth."
Though it is spoken of in that way,
It does not exist in that way.

Ānanda, it is in this way that the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, teaches the bodhisattva, the great being, as "the eighth."

Ānanda, if you ask how the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, teaches the bodhisattva, the great being, as a stream-enterer: Ānanda, "stream" is said of the path. The path of the Buddha is inconceivable. The bodhisattva, the great being, abides in it in the manner of nonabiding, without joining, without separating, in the manner of one liberated from all dharmas. He attains the stream of the Buddha and is inclined toward it. The bodhisattva, the great being, attains that path in which all dharmas are ungrasped, unabiding, unobserved, without support, without substance, and in which no dharma is established. He has steadfast diligence, steadfast power, and steadfast intelligence; he does not have laziness or anything at odds with diligence. He is not attached to that path, nor does he abide in it, and with that path he seeks all dharmas. He seeks in this way: he becomes absorbed in the sameness of all dharmas, the sameness of obscurations and obstructions, and the sameness of all dharmas and the qualities of the Buddha; by seeing through the view of the transitory collection, he generates the Buddha's view, which generates no view; he demolishes the perception of the transitory

collection, and he wholly passes beyond the perception of self. Therefore he is called "a stream-enterer."

He is not attached even to the path of the Buddha, and attains nonattachment. He has no doubt about the awakening of the Buddha. Nor does he hold moral discipline as supreme: since he does not truly see even the moral discipline of the Buddha, he does not hold moral discipline as supreme. His is not a moral discipline that is examined; it is not a moral discipline that is investigated. He has completely passed beyond the three fetters. He does not abide in the three realms. He attains the path of the Buddha, and actually enters the path of the Buddha, the path without objects, the path without attachment, free of all attachment. He has no regard for body or life. He gives away every gift there is. He does not frown in anger. He gives gifts with awakening in view. To liberate all beings from suffering, to establish them in nirvāṇa, to demolish all signs, and to bring forth the signless Dharma, there is nothing he will not give away. Since he is free of the perception of beings, he is without timidity when he goes into an assembly, and he teaches the Dharma of peace that purifies the path of awakening. Since he is free of fear and dread, he is not afraid even of death. Why is that? Because he has attained the path of peace: he has attained the path of the Buddha, free of attachment, blissful, the path called "without coming and without going," the path of sameness that destroys everything, free of elaboration. Therefore that bodhisattva, the great being, is called "a stream-enterer."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses:

I have said that "stream" means the path:
The inconceivable path of the Buddha.
Whoever here abide in it in any way,
Each and every one of them is bound for the stream.

The path is like space:
It does not abide in any dharma,
It is without object and without support;
In it there is no substance.

The path by which the unsurpassed
Protector of the world goes forth,
That very path is attained
By the bodhisattva of steady mindfulness.

He has no attachment to that path,
And by means of the path he seeks;
Therefore he has entered the stream,
And has no attachment to the Buddha's path.

What is spoken of as the perception of saṃsāra
Is just like the perception of the Buddha;
One who has entered sameness there
Should be known as a stream-enterer.

Because he sees the path of the Buddha,
All the obscurations and obstructions
That there are on this path of the Buddha
He has completely abandoned.

Thinking of it as one's own body,
One generates a view even about the Victor;
Whatever has become a view of the Buddha,
That view he has cleared away.

The view of self is utterly evil;
Whatever view of self, whatever view of the transitory collection,
That view he has demolished;
Therefore he has no attachment to the path.

Whatever doubt he had before
About the attainment of awakening,
By clearing it away he attains nonattachment
And fully enters the path of the Buddha.

Whatever in him had become the holding
Of his own moral discipline and the Buddha's discipline as supreme,
That perception of moral discipline he has abandoned,
And he does not conceive of it again.

He has cut the three fetters
And does not abide in the three realms.
He has attained the qualities of the Buddha
And demolished the perception of beings.

By the path that is without object
He has entered upon the Buddha's awakening;
The untroubled path of the Buddha,

The path of peace, he has attained.

He delights in giving away;
His face shows no angry frown,
And so no one does him harm.
For the sake of awakening he is free of elaboration;
There is nothing he will not give away.
He frees the multitudes from suffering;
Therefore that stream-enterer
Establishes them in supreme liberation.

For him there are no signs,
Nor is there signlessness anywhere;
Therefore, in this world and
Elsewhere too, he has no fear.

Dharma and non-dharma,
Both of these he has completely abandoned;
Because he is free of name and form,
He has no fear in this world.

When he goes into an assembly
He is always without fear;
He purifies the path of awakening
And fully teaches the Dharma of peace.

Whatever perception of beings he had,
Those perceptions he has demolished;
Therefore he has no obscuration,
And he has demolished every fear.
Because he has abandoned the root of fear,
He has no fear of death.

Blissful, stainless, free of desire,
He has attained the path of peace.
He knows the sameness of the lower destinies,
And so he does not fear them.

Ungrasped, the same, and unmoving:
This path, rightly and fully explained,
Belongs to the bodhisattvas.

When I spoke of "stream-enterers,"
It was for the sake of those beings
Who are inclined to lesser dharmas.

By means exceedingly subtle
I have fully taught the qualities of the Buddha;
Those who set out for awakening
Are led onward in this way.
Just as those who sought the Buddha's Dharma
Practiced in times past,
So the Guide, steadfast in means and wisdom,
Teaches the Dharma.

Ānanda, it is with this in mind
That I fully spoke of stream-enterers;
But beings of small intelligence
Have taken it to mean something else.

Ānanda, with this intention
I spoke of stream-enterers;
Beings who have intelligence
Understand this approach.
Those unskilled in what is profound,
Dull, with the minds of children,
Do not understand the hidden meaning,
And because they do not understand, they dispute.

In the many thousands of teachings
In which I spoke of stream-enterers,
The word "stream-enterer"
Is taught as a quality of the Buddha.

Ānanda, it is in this way that the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, teaches the bodhisattva, the great being, as a stream-enterer.

Ānanda, if you ask how the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, teaches the bodhisattva, the great being, as a once-returner: Ānanda, here the bodhisattva follows after that wisdom. Through many conditions he searches for the wisdom of the Buddha, the knowledge by which awakening is accomplished. He searches everywhere for the wisdom of the Buddha, the wisdom that cuts off all conditions. He searches for the concentration that

pervades space, that truly passes beyond all concentrations, and that clears away all afflictions. In order to realize the sameness of all dharmas through the sameness of all the qualities of the Buddha, he attains the nature of all dharmas. He searches for the nature of reality, which he has not yet attained, in which the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete Buddhas, have found their footing. He does not observe any being who could shake him, and because beings cannot shake him, he searches for the dharma element.

He searches for the wisdom of the Buddha, thinking, "Alas, beings are for the most part of small intelligence, deeply afflicted by suffering, and wretched because they are unskilled in the dharma element. I must establish them in knowledge of the dharma element." He searches for the wisdom of the Buddha, thinking, "I must understand the faculties, the powers, the limbs of awakening, the concentrations, the liberations, the meditative absorptions and the attainments, and I must bring beings to understand them too." He searches for the wisdom by which awakening is realized. He searches for the eye of the Buddha, unobscured and inconceivable, the eye by which the welfare of the world is accomplished, and for that knowledge of the eye; and he searches for the wisdom by which all dharmas are known just as they are, the supreme among all forms of knowledge. He does not find even the wisdom by which he seeks out beings. Thinking, "I shall establish them in the wisdom that knows all dharmas as well established," he therefore comes here. Having come, in order to seek the inconceivable element, he sees the element of beings, and yet he does not find that element; therefore he comes. How could he ever find a being that is truly established? Since he does not understand beings to be truly established, he fully knows the element of beings. He also sees why beings are designated and spoken of. Having seen all beings and the dharma element, he sees that all beings are rightly inclined toward the dharma element. He sees the path of the Buddha, the path equal to the dharma element, the path in which beings are not observed, the path of the wisdom of the sameness of beings; and he seeks the wisdom of such an incomparable path, free of desire, stainless and pure. He does not find even the wisdom by which he knows it. Having attained the wisdom by which bodhisattvas are distinguished, he searches for it and comes here; therefore he is called "a once-returner."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The wisdom of the Buddha is limitless;
He goes in pursuit of that wisdom.

Because he seeks the wisdom of the Buddha,
He is one who comes once.

The many conditions that have been taught,
Through which awakening is accomplished:
Thinking, "I must know those conditions,"
He comes here seeking them.

Concentration that pervades space,
Supreme, clearing away all afflictions:
He strives hard for its sake,
And he comes to accomplish it.

The sublime nature of reality
That the All-Knowing Ones have found:
Thinking, "I must attain it,"
He comes here to seek it.

From the sublime dharma element
No being whatever is moved;
In order to understand them,
He simply comes once.

Many beings of small intelligence
Suffer and are wretched;
Thinking, "I shall establish them in wisdom,"
He seeks the wisdom of the Buddha.

The limbs of awakening, the faculties, the powers,
The concentrations and the liberations that are taught:
In order to search them out,
He seeks the wisdom of the Buddha.

Where the buddhas of the past dwelt and dwelt,
He seeks the seat of awakening;
Because he comes to seek it,
He is one who comes once.

The eye of the Buddha has no obscuration;
This eye is unsurpassed.
Because he seeks the eye of the Buddha,
He is one who comes once.

Just as the buddhas, protectors of the world,
The saviors, have sought it,
So he seeks that discernment,
Supreme among all forms of knowledge.

The wisdom by which all dharmas
Are known just as they are, and beings
Are not observed: thus he seeks that path,
And so it is the path that he seeks.

Thinking, "I shall establish them in the unsurpassed,"
With knowledge he seeks out many beings;
Because he seeks them out,
He is a once-returner.

Having come, the knowing one sees
The inconceivable element of beings;
He seeks the element of beings,
And so he is one who comes once.

In the element that he seeks
There are no beings,
And in seeking them he does not find them;
And so he is one who comes once.

He does not in any way obtain
Beings or the dharma element,
Yet he fully knows the element
Through which beings appear.

He sees that all dharmas without exception
Are hollow and empty, without core;
With a mind in meditative equipoise
He seeks the path of the Buddha.

That wisdom is like this:
Stainless, pure, and free of desire;
The wisdom by which it is known,
That wisdom is not found.

The irreproachable bodhisattva
Attains that wisdom
By which beings are distinguished,

For whose sake he has come here.

Ānanda, when with this in mind
I taught of the once-returner,
Beings of small intelligence
Took it in a wrong way.

Ānanda, it is with this in mind
That I spoke of the once-returner;
Great beings who are diligent
Understand this approach in that way.

Skilled in the intention and discerning,
Thoroughly certain of the profound meaning,
Having attained that meaning,
They accomplish awakening.

Ānanda, it is in this way that the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, teaches the bodhisattva, the great being, as a once-returner.

Ānanda, if you ask how the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, teaches the bodhisattva, the great being, as a non-returner: Ānanda, here the bodhisattva, the great being, has wholly passed beyond partial conduct and has attained the conduct of the Buddha. He has given up all conduct and completely abandoned it. He does not abide in any dharma; he is without abiding and without support. Therefore he does not return. Through the nature of reality he does not truly see any coming or going. He has completely passed beyond ordinary beings, has completely abandoned the perception of ordinary beings, and has demolished even the Buddha; and he possesses the dharma that is without support. Why is that? Because he has attained the element of peace, and in it he observes neither ordinary beings nor the Buddha, the guide of the world.

He has passed beyond the lower realms, and desire is wholly cut off. In order to destroy completely all that has become view, he attains the awakening that is free of nourishment. Because he has no clinging to the sixty-two views, he is free of entity and nonentity. He is like nirvāṇa. In order to reverse the perception of nirvāṇa and not to engage in any perception, he has purified all dharmas, the lower realms, and the stains. He has vanquished Māra, the Evil One. He is free of intoxication. He has pulled out the thorn of ignorance. He has dried up existence. He has cleared away the desire of delight. He has

cleared away the afflictions. He has expelled all perceptions. He has pulled out the thorn of sorrow. He is free of pride, and even of pride in that. He has attained the light of fully understanding the aggregates. Therefore he attains, in the wisdom of the Buddha, the inconceivable sameness of wisdom.

Therefore that bodhisattva, the great being, unattached to the swamp of the desire realm, attains the coming forth of the buddhas of the past. He attains the treasure of the buddhas of the past, the treasure laid down by the buddhas of the past, from which nothing is taken away and to which nothing is added. He attains the vehicle of the Buddha, which has room for all beings, chief and unsurpassed. In an unobstructed way, in the way in which all signs are signless, he attains the element of peace in which all doubts are cut off. Therefore, again, he does not come here.

Moreover, Ānanda, thinking, "I shall establish in awakening those beings whom I have taken up," he established them. How did he establish them in awakening? He made them understand awakening without beings, and raised them out of the perception of beings. Why is that? He knows the element of beings to be empty. What is empty is inconceivable, and is free of the perception of beings. Why is that? Because he knows the element of beings to be empty like the element of space, free of beings, and yet not free of beings. That element of space too does not exist as the element of space; it does not abide. That element of space is empty of space itself, and all signs of beings are vanquished.

He attains signless awakening, and is free of the perception of beings and of space. He realizes the dharma element to be like the element of space. Why is that? It is like this: all dharmas and all beings are by their intrinsic nature the dharma element. Why is that? Because he does not observe them, and since he does not observe them, he does not come here again. Therefore he is counted among those called "non-returners." He is not counted among all dharmas, yet he has entered the count of the buddhas, and so he is called "a non-returner."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses:

To whatever is partial conduct
He does not go again;
Because he has abandoned partial conduct,
He is said to be "a non-returner."

He knows that beings have no going;
He does not find even the slightest abiding;
Because he does not abide in any dharma,
He is held to be "a non-returner."

What is spoken of as ordinary beings,
And the protector of the world, the perfect Buddha:
To these he does not come again;
Therefore he is called "a non-returner."

Here neither the coming
Nor the going of dharmas is observed;
Because he has attained no coming and no going,
He is said to be "a non-returner."

To any of the three destinies
He does not go again;
Because he has attained the qualities of the Buddha,
He is said to be "a non-returner."

All desires are completely cut off;
He has no attachment to food;
Because he has attained the path of awakening,
He is said to be "a non-returner."

The views of the evil-minded,
The sixty-two views that are taught:
To these he does not go;
Therefore he is a non-returner.

These dharmas have no intrinsic nature;
They are forever free of entity;
He knows this truly, just as it is;
Therefore he does not come here.

The peace of nirvāṇa that has been taught,
Which clears away all afflictions:
He has reversed the perception of it;
Therefore he does not come here.

All the lower realms are completely cut off,
Because he is free of stains;
He has attained the peace of nirvāṇa;

Therefore he does not come here.

He has vanquished Māra, the Evil One,
Together with his army and his mounts;
That wisdom of his is free of conceptual thought;
Therefore he does not come here.

He has torn apart the net of ignorance
And vanquished all craving;
He fully understands the desire of delight;
Therefore he does not come here.

He has fully tamed all afflictions
And demolished the perception of entities;
He is certain of this supreme vehicle;
He is called "a non-returner."

He has pulled out the thorn of sorrow,
And has surely vanquished all pride;
He fully understands all the aggregates;
He is called "a non-returner."

The vehicle of the Buddha is inconceivable;
In this vehicle he has attained the light;
He has no attachment to the swamp of desire;
Therefore he does not come here.

Among all treasures, he has
The supreme and sublime treasure of wisdom
Laid down by the buddhas of the past;
Therefore he does not come here.

The vehicle of the Buddha is unsurpassed;
He abides in this supreme vehicle,
And all his doubts are cut off;
Therefore he does not come here.

Thinking, "I shall establish them in awakening,"
He took up many beings,
And established them in awakening;
Therefore he does not come here.

The inconceivable element of beings,
And the empty expanse, he knows;
He is free of that perception;
Therefore he does not come here.

He fully knows the element of beings to be empty,
And knows the dharma element;
In it he finds no beings;
Therefore he does not come here.

Toward any sign at all
His mind does not engage again;
He has attained the signless state;
Therefore he does not come here.

The inconceivable element of beings,
Like space, and that element,
And all beings, he fully knows;
Therefore he does not come here.

Ānanda, it is with this in mind
That I spoke of the non-returner;
That all dharmas are unborn
Is taught as the quality of the Buddha.

Ānanda, it is in this way that the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, teaches the bodhisattva, the great being, as a non-returner.

The third fascicle.

Ānanda, if you ask how the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, teaches the bodhisattva, the great being, as an arhat: Ānanda, here the bodhisattva, the great being, has destroyed every practice of limited conduct, and is worthy to accomplish the conduct that liberates all beings. He has destroyed all afflictions, and he is worthy to free from those afflictions the beings who suffer, yet he observes neither those beings nor those afflictions. In this way he is called "an arhat."

He has destroyed every apprehension of form. He abides in the nonobservation of the emptiness of all dharmas and of the peace of all dharmas, and therefore he knows all dharmas to be empty. He realizes them as signless. He is free of all signs. He has destroyed all perception of the lower realms. He realizes the dharma in which there are no beings. He fully knows all

dharmas to be empty. He is worthy to attain awakening and worthy to accomplish the inconceivable awakening of the Buddha; therefore he is called "an arhat."

He is worthy to teach the Dharma. He is worthy to teach the Dharma free of elaboration and free of turbidity, as the perfectly complete buddhas of the past taught it, as those of the present teach it, and as those yet to come will teach it; therefore he is called "an arhat."

He is worthy to establish beings in awakening, so that they may understand all dharmas, be free of elaboration, and be without grasping. He is worthy to accomplish the loving-kindness of the Buddha, the loving-kindness of a love that has no clinging to beings. He is worthy to establish beings in that loving-kindness too. In the loving-kindness that does not observe beings, he does not observe those beings, and he is worthy to establish them as well; therefore he is called "an arhat."

In order to uphold all dharmas, he is worthy to teach the Dharma to beings, and he has no perception of the Dharma as Dharma. Because he is worthy in this way, he is called "an arhat."

He is worthy to teach living creatures the faculties, the powers, and the branches of awakening; he has attained nonattachment even to these, and he has no clinging to any thing whatsoever. Therefore he is called "an arhat."

He is worthy of all the honors that are to be found in the world, however many they may be, yet he is not stained by them and not attached to them. And so that others too may be unstained by honor and unattached to it, he is worthy to teach the Dharma to sentient beings. Therefore he is called "an arhat."

In the manner of not going, he is worthy to go to the buddha fields, and there too he looks upon the buddhas, the blessed ones, in the manner of not seeing. Just as a buddha beholds the buddhas, so is he worthy to look upon them. Therefore he is called "an arhat."

He is worthy to accomplish fields such as these, in the manner in which no dharma is accomplished: an inconceivable field, a field without obscurations, a field where the māras are vanquished, a field equal to the unequaled, a field free of elaboration, a field without turbidity, an empty field, an irreversible field, a field without women, a field without afflictions, a field of the Buddha's eloquence, a field without opponents, and a field of utter, complete nirvāṇa. Because he is worthy to accomplish such fields, he is called "an arhat."

He is not attached even to the things that give rise to attachment, and he is not disturbed even by the things that give rise to disturbance. Therefore he is called "an arhat."

He knows the vehicle that is equal to cessation, he realizes the vehicle of the buddhas, and he is worthy to set forth in detail the awakening of the buddhas, the blessed ones, which he has discerned. Because beings are unmoving, that awakening is inconceivable; and in order to make them unmoving, he is worthy to establish many tens of millions of beings in awakening. For those who abide in sameness, neither all beings nor awakening are conceptualized. He is worthy to lead beings directly into sameness. Just as in sameness there is no sameness, so too all dharmas are equal to that. As sameness is, so too is awakening: it abides equally in nonconceptuality, and the arhat too is equal to it. He is worthy in this way as well: having understood it thus, he is worthy to teach the Dharma to beings in just that way. He mixes no dharma with any other; possessing the Dharma that is taught without mixing, he is worthy to teach the Dharma in that way, and yet not to express it even in words.

He frees beings from perceiving them as beings to be observed. He frees beings from permanence and annihilation. He moves beings away from the view of the perishing collection, and turns them utterly away from the pride that thinks "I am." He frees them from the nonarising, the noncessation, and the nonformation of all dharmas. He frees them from the nondisintegration of form, and from the nondisintegration of feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness. He frees them from the immovability of the qualities of ordinary beings, and from not setting down and from setting forth the qualities of a buddha. He frees them from perceiving the fruit of stream entry, and from perceiving the fruits of once-returner, non-returner, and arhat. He frees them from perceiving a pratyekabuddha, and from clinging to the perception of a bodhisattva. He frees them from clinging to generosity undertaken for the sake of awakening, and from clinging to moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration, and wisdom undertaken for the sake of awakening. He frees them from clinging to the superknowledges, and from clinging to the accomplishment of calm abiding and insight. He frees them from clinging to birth as a śrāvaka. He frees them from clinging to brothers, sisters, relatives, and ties of blood. He frees them from attachment to not seeing the self, and from clinging to fondness, to the perishing collection, and to busy company. He frees them from clinging to gain and honor. He frees them from clinging to seeing people as householders and as renunciants. He frees them from

clinging to seeing dharmas as inferior and supreme. He frees them from clinging to rejecting the qualities of ordinary beings and fixing special attention on the qualities of a buddha. He frees them from clinging to seeing inferior and excellent dharmas. He frees them from clinging to the accomplishment of the perfectly complete marks, and from clinging to accomplishing it all in the manner of purifying a buddha field.

He frees them from clinging to the arising of a mind that divides things in two, thinking: "These beings are of a nature to pass into complete nirvāṇa; these beings are not of a nature to pass into complete nirvāṇa. These have the good fortune to attain it; these lack the good fortune to attain it. These practice for the sake of awakening; these do not practice for the sake of awakening. These are of bad character; these possess moral discipline. These have faulty wisdom; these possess wisdom." He frees them from clinging to a mind that divides things in two in this way, thinking: "These are worthy recipients of giving; these are not worthy recipients of giving. These possess diligence; these lack diligence. These are the qualities of fools; these are the qualities of the wise. These are the qualities of men; these are the qualities of women. These are the qualities of the noble ones; these are not the qualities of the noble ones." He frees them from the conceptual thought of a mind arising in this way, thinking: "These are irreversible from awakening; these turn back from awakening. These have received a prophecy; these have not received a prophecy. These are near; these are not near." And he frees them from clinging to passing into nirvāṇa without appropriation once awakening has been attained.

By freeing them in these ways, he is worthy to free many beings. By teaching that beings have no intrinsic nature, he is worthy to free beings in this way, and so he is called "an arhat."

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Whatever conduct is partial,
All such conduct he knows;
What is partial, he knows completely;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

All the afflictions by which beings
Suffer so intensely he has destroyed;
He frees beings from the afflictions;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

He has utterly destroyed all objectification;
He abides well in nonobjectification;
He knows the nature of reality as emptiness;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

He knows emptiness and peace,
And so realizes signlessness;
He is entirely free of signs;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

The perception of beings is grievously harmful;
All perceptions he has destroyed;
Because he has abandoned all perceptions,
He is said to possess arhatship.

He has utterly destroyed all unknowing;
He has realized the nature of reality, which is without mind;
He fully knows dharmas to be empty;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

The awakening of the buddhas is inconceivable;
He is worthy to truly attain awakening;
He undertakes sublime diligence;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

He is truly worthy to teach the Dharma
That is free of elaboration and free of turbidity;
He establishes beings in wisdom;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

He is worthy to practice the loving-kindness
By which beings come to happiness,
Yet he does not objectify those beings;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

He is truly worthy to teach the Dharma
Of not grasping any dharmas at all;
He has no perception of the Dharma as Dharma;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

He is worthy to teach beings
The branches of awakening and the powers,
And has gained nonattachment even to these;

Therefore he is called an arhat.

He is worthy to make beings know
The pure Dharma for the sake of awakening;
To them he teaches wisdom;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

He is worthy, from all beings,
Of all the honors of the world,
Yet he has no attachment to any honor;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

He is worthy to go to the field,
The most excellent buddha field,
Where, having attained perfect buddhahood, they dwell
And teach the Dharma to living creatures.
Thinking, "I too shall accomplish
An excellent field like this,"
He is worthy to accomplish it;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

Unattached to what gives rise to attachment,
Undisturbed by what gives rise to disturbance,
Because he has realized awakening, which is peace,
Therefore he is called an arhat.

He knows the nature of cessation;
He realizes whatever is peace;
He has discerned awakening;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

Of all the realms of beings,
He causes no being to waver;
Many tens of millions of beings
He establishes in awakening.
All beings and awakening
Abide just as they are, beyond concept;
Thus he knows that very sameness;
Therefore he is called an arhat.

In sameness there is no sameness;
All dharmas are equal to that.
Through sameness, that awakening,
Awakening, abides beyond concept.
Since he is worthy to know it thus,
Therefore he is called an arhat.

Having known, he teaches beings,
And in no way does he give rise to affliction.
Though he teaches the Dharma in this way,
There is no expressing it in words.
Many tens of millions of beings
He establishes in awakening.

He knows beings cannot be objectified.
Beings who grasp at permanence and annihilation,
Beings who are not moved from their views,
Those suffering ones he sets free.

From their perceptions of all dharmas
As unborn, unceasing, and unconditioned
He turns them back,
And sets them free from suffering.

He sees form, feeling, perception,
Formations, and consciousness,
And from the notion that the aggregates do not disintegrate
He sets embodied beings free.

Toward the qualities of ordinary beings
He does not waver in any way;
He does not set them up,
And he does not abide in the qualities of a buddha.

Those who perceive the attainment of the fruits,
Those who hold the perception of pratyekabuddhas,
Those who perceive buddhas:
He frees them from their perceptions.

Clinging to the mind of awakening,
And clinging to generosity and the rest:
So that there may be no clinging at all,

He teaches the nature of reality.

Because they have objectified laziness,
They imagine the undertaking of diligence;
To free them from such conceptions,
He is worthy to teach the Dharma.

Perceptions of concentration and distraction,
Perceptions of wisdom and faulty wisdom:
So that there may be no clinging to either,
He is worthy to teach the Dharma.

"Do not conceptualize dharmas;
Know them to be unchanging!"
Because he teaches the Dharma in this way,
Therefore he is called an arhat.

Those who, clinging to a self,
Imagine śrāvakas in many ways:
To free them from their conceptions,
He is worthy to teach the Dharma.

The unskilled cling to father, mother,
And wife as their own;
This is not the path to awakening;
It is the domain of saṃsāra.

Thinking, "This is my brother, my sister,"
They delight in them and cling to them;
They follow the ways of wild beasts;
It is right that they be set free.

Not fully understanding the perishing collection,
They give rise to the perception of kin;
Seeing someone, they think, "He was my kinsman before,"
And they rejoice greatly.

Having seen, they become attached,
And are fond of one another;
Inverted by wrong perception,
They have fallen under the power of Māra.

"The perishing collection is utterly evil;
Understand the perishing collection fully!
The perishing collection has these faults."
In this way he teaches the Dharma.

"These are dharmas of complete affliction;
These are dharmas of purification":
Because he has no clinging to such duality,
That wise one is called an arhat.

Those attached through attachment to gain,
Made heedless by honor:
To free them from attachment and heedlessness,
He is worthy to teach the Dharma.

They think, "These have gone forth;
These are householders."
Fools who conceive in this way
He is worthy to set free.

They see dharmas as inferior;
They see them also as vast;
Fools who see through conceptions
He is worthy to set free.

"Having cast aside the qualities of fools,
I have attained the nature of a buddha":
To free them from attaining and not attaining,
He is worthy to teach the Dharma.

Through distinctions of inferior and excellent
They see dharmas in many ways;
To free them from their many perceptions,
He teaches the Dharma.

Those who strive in many ways
To accomplish the marks of a buddha,
The wise one sets free
From clinging to the marks.

"I shall accomplish a perfect,
Supreme field":
Clinging to that perception

He is worthy to set free.

Those who have passed into nirvāṇa and those who have not,
Dharmas with the fortune to attain and without it,
"These practice for the sake of awakening;
These have not entered upon awakening;
Of bad character, and possessed of discipline;
Of faulty wisdom, and possessed of wisdom":
Those who have the minds of fools
Make such divisions in two.
Perceiving beings in this way,
Conceitedly thinking of them in many ways:
To free them from these perceptions,
He is worthy to teach the Dharma.

"Worthy recipients of giving, and not worthy":
So they conceive of each apart;
Into the qualities of the wise and of fools
They make separate distinctions.
Here they objectify the qualities of women,
And conceive of being male;
Thus noble and ignoble dharmas,
Two kinds, they conceive apart.
Those who divide things in two in this way,
The unskilled, of small understanding:
So that they may understand nonduality,
He is worthy to teach the Dharma.

Turning back from supreme awakening,
Not turning back, prophesied,
Not prophesied, near,
And not near: so they conceive.
"Having attained awakening, without appropriation,
With defilements exhausted, he passes into complete nirvāṇa":
Those who practice with signs
Conceive of nirvāṇa in such a way.
From holding to perceptions such as these
That gentle one sets them free.
Because he utterly releases all perceptions,

Therefore he is called an arhat.

The qualities of the bodhisattvas
I have taught as "arhat."
Those who develop acceptance of this,
Know them to be arhats!

Ānanda, in this way the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha has fully taught that bodhisattva great beings are arhats.

Ānanda, if you ask how the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha has fully taught that bodhisattva great beings are śrāvakas: Ānanda, here the bodhisattva great being proclaims the qualities of a buddha to immeasurable beings, proclaiming, "Awakening is peace, free of elaboration, free of turbidity." Because he proclaims in this way, he is called a śrāvaka.

He proclaims the bliss of nirvāṇa, saying, "There is no other bliss like this"; he proclaims, "Accomplish the faculties, the powers, the branches of awakening, and the applications of mindfulness!"; and he proclaims, "This vehicle is supreme." Because he proclaims in this way, the bodhisattva himself is called a śrāvaka.

He proclaims, "This body is empty; no essence is found in it; it is what deludes fools. Therefore take the body apart!" And he proclaims, "See this eye sense source as seeing falsely! Accomplish the wholly inconceivable eye of a buddha! Accomplish, in the manner of nonaccomplishment, that eye by which one is never deluded anywhere!" Proclaim it thus! Because he proclaims all dharmas in this way, he is called a śrāvaka.

He proclaims that all sounds are like echoes: "Do not cling to sounds! Here there is nothing heard. Here there is nothing spoken." Therefore he is called a śrāvaka.

"Do not perceive odors as odors! Here there is nothing smelled. It is like this: a man asleep may smell many kinds of odors in a dream, yet because there is no real thing, there is no odor at all there; rather, he smells through error. In the same way, the nose is erroneous; because it is like a dream, know that there is no essence in it!" So he proclaims; therefore he is called a śrāvaka.

He proclaims the tongue sense source thus: "This is a lump of flesh; it does not taste flavors. The lump of flesh, too, is like a mass of foam, like a dream. The example, too, is without substance." So he proclaims; therefore he is called a

śrāvaka.

"Take apart the body sense source! This body is empty of intrinsic nature. What is empty of intrinsic nature is a nonthing. What is a nonthing is unborn and does not arise. What is unborn and does not arise is itself awakening." So he proclaims; and because he proclaims this to many beings, he is called a śrāvaka.

He proclaims, "The mind is without intrinsic nature, a nonthing, of the nature of an illusion, without arising, without cessation." Because he proclaims this, he is called a śrāvaka.

"Give the gift of the Dharma! This gift of the Dharma is the path to awakening. That awakening is inconceivable; through the inconceivable one accomplishes the inconceivable. Why is that? As the seed is, so is the fruit; and it is spoken of in words as being without fruit." So he proclaims.

"Give material gifts! This material gift is small; compared with it, the gift of the Dharma is foremost.

Do not be stingy in this! Do not perceive giving as giving! Do not perceive it as an essence! Give gifts with a nonconceptual mind! Just as an illusory man gives a gift to an illusory man with a nonconceptual mind, in the same way give gifts with a nonconceptual mind! If you give in this way, awakening will come to full ripeness." So he proclaims, and because he proclaims in this way, he is called a śrāvaka.

Why is that? Because he has fully accomplished nondual wisdom, the very essence of wisdom; and just as he has accomplished it, so he proclaims the qualities of a buddha as nondual and undivided. Therefore he is called a śrāvaka.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The fearless bodhisattva
Proclaims to many beings
The inconceivable qualities of a buddha;
Therefore he is called a śrāvaka.

He proclaims awakening as peace,
Free of elaboration, free of turbidity;
He proclaims it to countless people;
Therefore he is called a śrāvaka.

"There is no other bliss like this":
He proclaims the bliss of nirvāṇa;
Because he proclaims peace, nirvāṇa,
Therefore he is called a śrāvaka.

"The powers, the branches of awakening,
The applications of mindfulness, and the faculties:
Swiftly accomplish them!" he proclaims;
This he proclaims to embodied beings.

"This body is empty and without essence;
It is what deludes fools;
Therefore take the body apart!"
This is what he proclaims.

"Understand the eye as mistaken!
It deludes the unskilled,
Those who have the minds of fools":
This is what he proclaims.

"Sounds are like echoes;
Know the ear, too, in this way!
Here there is nothing heard,
And nothing that speaks."
Because he proclaims this
To many beings, he is held to be a śrāvaka.

"Here there is nothing heard;
Take no delight in this sound!
For example, a man in a dream
Smells many kinds of odors,
Yet they are not established as things;
He smells them in error."
Having understood odors in this way,
"Here there is nothing smelled,"
He proclaims to others as well,
To the erring and the unskilled.

"This tongue is a lump of flesh;
It does not taste flavors.
If flesh could know flavor,
The hand too would know flavor," he proclaims.

"The perception of flavor is grievously harmful;
Destroy these perceptions!
The element of flavor is inconceivable;
That element is not something realized."
Because the bodhisattva does not abide,
For him it has become directly perceived;
Since he proclaims direct perception in this way,
Therefore he is called a śrāvaka.

"This body, by its essential nature,
Is empty": thus he takes it apart.
What is empty by essential nature
Is unborn and does not arise;
What is unborn and does not arise,
That, here, is awakening itself.
Thus he proclaims to beings;
Therefore he is called a śrāvaka.

"This mind, by its essential nature,
Is without intrinsic nature, a nonthing;
It is not a being, not a thing":
This is what he proclaims.

"The gift of the Dharma is inconceivable;
This is the path to awakening;
Through it awakening will be accomplished;
So give gifts!" he proclaims.

"Give material gifts of various kinds,
Many kinds, and pure;
If there is no stinginess in them,
That too is the path to awakening."

Because he has cut off the afflictions,
Is wholly free of the defilements,
And has utterly passed beyond all attachment,
Therefore he is called a śrāvaka.

The wise one proclaims
The unsurpassed qualities of a buddha;
All sounds are sublime and at peace;

Through this the sublime essence is accomplished.
He directly knows every essence,
Yet abides in no essence at all;
Nondual, undivided into two,
He proclaims the sublime proclamation.

Just as the teachings of the Dharma
Of many buddhas are proclaimed,
So the gentle one, having set out for awakening,
Here sets them forth in this way.

Where the buddhas, protectors of the world,
Dwell, unsurpassed,
In those buddha fields, the most excellent,
And in those closed off as well, he proclaims.

He proclaims to this trichiliocosm,
Which rests in space:
"Beings are just like space,
Forever equal to nirvāṇa.
The four elements that are spoken of,
From which beings are imagined,
Are like space,
Beyond concept and beyond thought.
The elements are like this;
See that there is no essence in them!
Here there is no birth and no death,
No nirvāṇa and no affliction;
Here nothing is established as a thing;
Here there are no beings.
Contemplate that element
Which no one ever sees!"
Day and night, without slackening,
He proclaims this to beings.

"I am proclaiming something":
No such conceit is in him at all.
Whoever proclaims to others in this way,
Know him to be a śrāvaka.

It is not by saying so that he is a śrāvaka;
He has been fully taught as a śrāvaka.

The steadfast one, whose mind is never lowly,
Teaches living creatures the Dharma
Through which all dharmas
Come to be known just as they are.

Freed from attachment and undefiled,
To free them from all attachment
He teaches the Dharma to living creatures;
He is called an arhat.

He also teaches the sphere
Free of elaboration, without turbidity, without attachment;
Having seen all the qualities of a buddha
Without exception, he teaches them.

What the buddhas have spoken
He does not conceive as far from the Dharma,
Nor does he conceive it as near to the Dharma;
Therefore in him there is no mixing.
Though he proclaims, there is no mixing,
And he speaks to countless beings,
Yet he does not see those beings;
Therefore he is called a śrāvaka.

Ānanda, with this in mind
I have fully taught the śrāvaka.
The bodhisattva who does not abide:
Know the śrāvaka to be such!

Ānanda, in this way the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha has fully taught that bodhisattva great beings are śrāvakas.

Ānanda, if you ask how the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha has fully taught that bodhisattva great beings are pratyekabuddhas: Ānanda, here the bodhisattva great being has direct perception of all dharmas.

If one asks how he has direct perception: because he superimposes nothing on any dharma, he is without affliction; and in the manner of denying no dharma, he realizes and comprehends that they do not disintegrate. Therefore he is

called a pratyekabuddha.

He realizes that all dharmas are beyond thought, and he knows that all beings, since they will not be born in the future, are like nirvāṇa; that they are unborn and unceasing; that the limit of reality is the limit of nirvāṇa; that the limit of beings is the limit of a mirage; that they are without substance and without entity; that the limit of all dharmas is inexpressible; that the limit of the inexpressible is the limit of the designation of names; that it does not abide in words; and that it is not expressed by words.

Why is that? Because words are hollow and empty; words do not know the limit of the self or the limit of beings. He has realized that limit, and since that limit has become directly perceived for him, he is called a pratyekabuddha.

That this form aggregate is expressed by sound; that this form aggregate is soundless and free of sound; that it is expressed in words as "this is always the form aggregate"; and that in it there is neither self nor anything belonging to a self: in this way the form aggregate has become directly perceived for him. Why is that? The words by which the form aggregate is expressed are hollow and empty, unborn and unceasing. In reality, words themselves are always nonexistent, so how could there be words that express the form aggregate? In this way the form aggregate has become directly perceived.

That this feeling aggregate is expressed by sound; that this feeling aggregate is soundless and free of sound; that it is expressed in words as "this is always the feeling aggregate"; and that in it there is neither self nor anything belonging to a self: in this way the feeling aggregate has become directly perceived. Why is that? The words by which the feeling aggregate is expressed are hollow and empty, unborn and unceasing. In reality, words themselves are always nonexistent, so how could there be words that express the feeling aggregate? In this way the feeling aggregate has become directly perceived.

That this perception aggregate is expressed by sound; that this perception aggregate is soundless and free of sound; that it is expressed in words as "this is always the perception aggregate"; and that in it there is neither self nor anything belonging to a self: in this way the perception aggregate has become directly perceived for him. Why is that? The words by which the perception aggregate is expressed are hollow and empty, unborn and unceasing. In reality, words themselves are always nonexistent. How could there be words that express the perception aggregate? In this way the perception aggregate has become directly perceived.

That this formations aggregate is expressed by sound; that this formations aggregate is soundless and free of sound; that it is expressed in words as "this is always the formations aggregate"; and that in it there is neither self nor anything belonging to a self: in this way the formations aggregate has become directly perceived for him. Why is that? The words by which the formations aggregate is expressed are hollow and empty, unborn and unceasing. In reality, words are always nonexistent, so how could there be words that express the formations aggregate? In this way the formations aggregate has become directly perceived.

That this consciousness aggregate is expressed by sound; that this consciousness aggregate is soundless and free of sound; that it is expressed in words as "this is always the consciousness aggregate"; and that in it there is neither self nor anything belonging to a self: in this way the consciousness aggregate has become directly perceived for him. Why is that? The words by which it is expressed as the consciousness aggregate are hollow and empty, unborn and unceasing. In reality, words are always nonexistent, so how could there be words that express the consciousness aggregate? In this way the consciousness aggregate is directly known.

Thus the five aggregates are soundless, and whatever words express them, they have become directly perceived for him. Therefore he is called a pratyekabuddha. Why is that? Because he has comprehended that words are soundless, that the conditionality of the aggregates is not conditionality, and that the conditionality of words is a conditionality that cannot be expressed. Therefore he is called a pratyekabuddha.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

All dharmas are undefiled,
Unborn and unceasing;
Forever utterly without signs,
All dharmas have become directly perceived.

These are empty by essential nature,
And essential nature, in reality,
Does not truly exist at all;
Thus all dharmas have become directly perceived.

Just as this Dharma is, so it is;
This has become direct perception itself;
Because the nature of reality is inconceivable,

Therefore he is called a pratyekabuddha.

All dharmas are nirvāṇa;
No beginning of them is found.
That limit of the unborn
Is called the limit of reality.

All dharmas are nirvāṇa,
Taught with certainty as unborn;
Whatever dharma is unborn
Is what is called nirvāṇa.

All dharmas are nirvāṇa;
It is merely expressed by a name.
Unborn and unceasing,
They are expressed through words.

Words are rightly said to be empty;
Words do not know beings.
Therefore, unborn and without abode,
Beings are said to be nirvāṇa.

Words are said to be hollow,
Unmoving and without thought;
These words, by the very nature of words,
Never truly exist at all.

The limit of beings, beyond thought,
Which words point to:
That limit does not rely on words,
Nor does it abide in words.

The limit of beings is nirvāṇa;
The limit of reality is no limit;
Free of elaboration, peaceful and blissful,
It is a dwelling, a refuge, and an ally.

Like the limit of a mirage
The limit of beings is taught with certainty;
Without entity and without object,
The limit of reality is inconceivable.

That limit of the nature of reality, too,
Is merely expressed by a name;
Whatever is expressed by a name,
That limit is not an object.

No one is able to express it
As directly perceived;
The limit of beings is inconceivable;
Thus the limit is hollow.

The limit does not abide in words;
It is not fully expressed by words.
Thus, in truth,
The limit of beings does not exist.

The words by which the limit of beings
Is shown to be inconceivable,
Those words are empty and hollow;
By them nothing at all is known.

Such an inconceivable limit
Is understood by oneself alone;
Therefore the one beyond reproach
Is called a pratyekabuddha, a solitary buddha.

This is not expressed by sound;
This, called another aggregate, has no sound.
As forever free of sound,
The aggregate of form is directly perceived.

This is utterly free,
And yet it is spoken of as real;
In reality, the real
Does not abide anywhere at all.

The words by which this aggregate is expressed,
Saying, "The aggregate of form is selfless,"
Those words are empty and hollow,
Unborn and without cessation.

In reality, in any way at all,
These words do not exist whatsoever;
It is with words that do not exist

That the aggregate of form is expressed.

This is not expressed by sound;
The aggregate of feeling has no sound.
As forever free of sound,
The aggregate of feeling is directly perceived.

This is utterly free,
And yet it is spoken of as real;
In reality, the real
Does not abide anywhere at all.

By words this aggregate of feeling
Has been declared to be hollow;
Those words are empty and hollow,
Unborn and without cessation.

In reality, at any time,
These words do not exist whatsoever;
It is with words that do not exist
That the aggregate of feeling is expressed.

This is not expressed by sound;
This aggregate has no sound.
As forever free of sound,
The aggregate of feeling is directly perceived.

This is utterly free,
And yet it is spoken of as real;
In reality, the real
Does not abide anywhere at all.

By words the aggregate is proclaimed:
"The aggregate of perception is selfless."
Those words are empty and hollow,
Unborn and without cessation.

In reality, at any time,
These words do not exist whatsoever;
It is with words that do not exist
That the aggregate of perception is expressed.

This is not expressed by sound;
This aggregate has no sound.
As forever free of sound,
The aggregate of perception is directly perceived.

This is utterly free,
And yet it is spoken of as real;
In reality, the real
Does not abide anywhere at all.

By words this aggregate of formations
Has been proclaimed to be hollow;
Those words are empty and hollow,
Unborn and without cessation.

In reality, at any time,
These words do not exist whatsoever;
It is with words that do not exist
That the aggregate of formations is expressed.

This is not expressed by sound;
This aggregate has no sound.
As forever free of sound,
The aggregate of consciousness is directly perceived.

This is utterly free,
And yet it is spoken of as real;
In reality, the real
Does not abide anywhere at all.

By words this aggregate of consciousness
Has been proclaimed to be hollow;
Those words are empty and hollow,
Unborn and without cessation.

In reality, at any time,
These words do not exist whatsoever;
It is with words that do not exist
That the aggregate of consciousness is expressed.

In the inexpressible aggregates
Nothing is apprehended as valid cognition;
For what is unborn and unceasing,

These have no abode and no support.

There are no afflictions and no freedom from them;
There are no phenomena and no karmic ripening;
There is no Buddha, no Dharma, and no Saṅgha;
There is no nirvāṇa and no self-arisen one.

There is no calm abiding whatsoever;
Nor is there insight.
There is no frugality with requisites and no fewness of desires;
There is no laziness and there is no diligence.

There is no agitation and there is no regret,
Nor is there any vow,
Because in this there is no entity established
As having become restrained.

Here there is no thought or conceptualization,
Nor is there nonconceptuality.
There is no fear and there is no wilderness;
There is no bondage and there is no liberation.

This is entered by means of sound,
Yet it is taught with certainty to be without entry.
All phenomena are soundless,
Yet they are expressed by sound itself.

Because this has been directly realized,
One teaches the inexhaustible way.
Relying on this concentration,
One is not attached to sound.

Of whatever kind, of whatever, whatever it may be,
That sound one knows directly.
All phenomena are thus equal,
Inexpressible and without abiding.

Because this has been directly realized,
One has gone from this shore to the far shore.
Therefore that one beyond reproach
Is called a self-perfected buddha.

Furthermore, Ānanda, that bodhisattva great being has directly realized, in ignorance, the intrinsic nature of ignorance; in formations, the intrinsic nature of formations; in consciousness, the intrinsic nature of consciousness; in name and form, the intrinsic nature of name and form; in the six sense sources, the intrinsic nature of the six sense sources; in contact, the intrinsic nature of contact; in feeling, the intrinsic nature of feeling; in craving, the intrinsic nature of craving; in grasping, the intrinsic nature of grasping; in becoming, the intrinsic nature of becoming; in birth, the intrinsic nature of birth; and in aging and death, the intrinsic nature of aging and death. Therefore he is called a pratyekabuddha.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

"This never exists at all":
Thus one has directly realized ignorance.
It is not established as an entity,
Like a reflection in water.

Ignorance is the abode of falsehood;
It mingles with no phenomenon at all.
That which mingles with no phenomenon
Is the characteristic of ignorance.

Ignorance is just like space;
All phenomena are without characteristics.
Because this has been directly realized,
One is called a solitary victor.

What are spoken of as bodily formations
Are nowhere at all within the body;
Not outside, nor outside and inside together,
Have they arisen anywhere at all.

Like the trunk of a plantain tree, they are without core,
Always utterly without core;
Unborn and unceased,
They are just like space.

Because this has been directly realized,
The fearless bodhisattva,
Inconceivable, is therefore
Called a self-perfected buddha.

Within a domain whose nature is illusion
He cognizes all phenomena;
That consciousness has the nature of illusion:
This he has directly realized.

This perception, the domain of consciousness,
He knows to be mistaken;
Having demolished perception,
He knows phenomena as emptiness.

He knows that knowing is not knowing;
He is not attached to anything at all.
Thus consciousness, a phenomenon designated by a name,
Is like an illusion.

Whatever is spoken of as name and form
Is spoken with a hidden intent;
Never at all is its entity
Established by intrinsic nature.

While sense sources do not exist,
These sense sources have been taught;
They are expressed by sound,
And they are empty from the very beginning.

Whatever contact of his had formerly
Arisen in reliance on the sense sources,
As hollow and illusory by nature,
That he demolishes.

Contact arises from conceptualization;
It is empty of essential nature.
No phenomenon of contact whatsoever
Abides by its essential nature.

"This is mistaken contact":
Thus the nature of contact is directly realized.
One perfected in the isolation of contact
Is called a solitary victor.

The three kinds of feeling he knows as empty,
As peaceful by their essential nature,
Like bubbles, without core,

Utterly hollow and vacuous.

All craving is completely cut off;
He knows the nature of reality free of craving.
Having attained the exhaustion of craving,
He is called a solitary victor.

Grasping is not grasping;
He demolishes it as empty.
It is not established as an entity,
Like water in a mirage.

Whatever perception of becoming he has,
Its remedy is the perception of it as baneful;
He knows that it is, by its nature,
Always utterly without entity.

For him there is no birth at all;
For him there is no death.
He will never be born
Anywhere at all.

Having understood these conditions,
He abides in nothing whatsoever;
Under the word "pratyekabuddha"
It is the bodhisattva who is taught.

Ānanda, in this way the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, has fully taught the bodhisattva great being as a pratyekabuddha.

The fourth fascicle.

Then, at that time, the venerable Ānanda spoke these verses:

"While there is no nirvāṇa, 'passed into nirvāṇa'
Is what the Protector of the World has said.
Having tied a knot in space,
It is untied by space itself.

The Buddha, who teaches the Dharma free of attachment,
Is skilled in means;
Here there is no speech at all,
And yet he utters speech."

Then the venerable Ānanda, having spoken these verses, said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, those who dwell in the world and do not understand the hidden speech of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, are bewildered here. They will not understand with what intent the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, has taught the faith-follower, the Dharma-follower, and likewise the eighth, the stream-enterer, the once-returner, the non-returner, the arhat, the śrāvaka, and the pratyekabuddha."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, those who have rendered service to the victors of the past will not be bewildered by this. Therefore, Ānanda, those bodhisattva great beings who have donned such armor, thinking, 'I shall understand this hidden speech of the Tathāgata,' will not be bewildered on this point. Those who come to possess diligence without apprehending diligence will not be bewildered by this. Those who come to possess knowledge that does not depend on others will not be bewildered by this."

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

"The hidden speech of the protectors, the saviors of the world,
Is extremely hard to understand;
The fearless bodhisattvas
Don armor for its sake.

The lazy and those of small intellect
Cannot understand the intent at all;
Therefore, for the sake of the hidden speech,
Take up diligence!

When one has understood the intent
Of the protectors, the saviors of the world,
Then one's knowledge
Sets about clarifying the hidden speech.

To realize it thus is awakening,
And it is attained by the bodhisattva.
Awakening is empty of expression,
And expression is empty of awakening.

The empty does not know the empty,
Yet one also says, 'empty, empty.'

The cutting off of all expression
Is taught as emptiness.

Space can never be grasped;
In it there is nothing to be grasped.
That in which there is nothing to be grasped,
Know that to be emptiness.

Those who come to abide in heedfulness
And thus come to know emptiness,
Those wise ones, on this point,
Will never be bewildered."

Then fifty million monks in that assembly who regarded themselves as faith-followers rose from their seats, gathered together, and in the presence of the Blessed One spoke this verse:

"Unsurpassed Protector of the World,
Buddha, we have no doubt;
Whatever you have taught with hidden intent,
We shall abide in supreme awakening."

Then, having heard that verse of those monks, another fifty million monks, different from them, who regarded themselves as Dharma-followers, rose from their seats, gathered together, sat in the presence of the Blessed One, and spoke this verse:

"What you have fully taught with hidden intent,
Calling it 'Dharma-follower,'
Of that we have no doubt;
We have attained the light of awakening."

Then, having heard that verse of those monks, another hundred million monks, different from them, who regarded themselves as eighth ones, rose from their seats, gathered together, sat in the presence of the Blessed One, and spoke this verse:

"Whatever perceptions we had of being eighth ones,
Those perceptions we have demolished;
The intent with which
'The eighth' was spoken, we have realized."

Then, having heard that verse of those monks, another hundred and ten million monks, who regarded themselves as stream-enterers, rose from their seats, gathered together, sat in the presence of the Blessed One, and spoke this verse:

"Today we have gained light
On the Buddha's Dharma in every way;
The intent for which stream-entry was taught,
That we understand."

Then, having heard that verse of those monks, other monks, hundreds of thousands of them, who regarded themselves as once-returners, rose from their seats, gathered together, sat in the presence of the Blessed One, and spoke this verse:

"We who had become attached
To being once-returners
Are today without attachment;
Noble One, we are free of elaboration."

Then, having heard that verse of those monks, eight hundred and fifty million monks who regarded themselves as having the fruit of the non-returner rose from their seats, gathered together, sat in the presence of the Blessed One, and spoke this verse:

"Supreme among humans, Protector of the World,
We have become free of elaboration;
Having crossed the chasm, today
We have gained light on awakening as well."

Then, having heard that verse of those monks, five hundred million monks who were meditators in the fourth meditative concentration rose from their seats, gathered together, sat in the presence of the Blessed One, and spoke this verse:

"Today we have become nothing at all;
We have realized the nature of reality without remainder.
In the equality of the illusory nature of reality
We understand all vehicles to be equal."

Then, having heard that verse of those monks, twenty thousand monks who had newly and genuinely entered the vehicle rose from their seats, gathered together, sat in the presence of the Blessed One, and spoke this verse:

"The intent with which you spoke of śrāvakas
In order to liberate embodied beings,
That intent we have realized:
It is neither true nor false."

Then, having heard that verse of those monks, five thousand monks who regarded themselves as pratyekabuddhas rose from their seats, gathered together, sat in the presence of the Blessed One, and spoke this verse:

"Pratyekabuddhahood is inconceivable;
What the Victor taught with hidden intent,
The awakening of the solitary victor,
Has today become directly manifest for us."

Then, having heard that verse of those monks, a million nuns, who regarded themselves as having the fruit of stream-entry, the fruit of the once-returner, the fruit of the non-returner, and the fruit of arhatship, rose from their seats, gathered together, sat in the presence of the Blessed One, and spoke this verse:

"We fully understand the phenomena that are equal
To the state of having become a woman;
As buddhas who need no one else to teach them,
We shall become supreme in the world."

Then, having heard that verse of those nuns, two million eight hundred thousand laymen, who regarded themselves as having the fruit of stream-entry, the fruit of the once-returner, and the fruit of the non-returner, rose from their seats, gathered together, sat in the presence of the Blessed One, and spoke this verse:

"Today our minds are without stain,
Utterly pure like beryl;
In order to attain the Buddha's Dharma,
Today we shall go forth."

Then sixty koṭis of niyutas of gods abiding in the sky scattered divine flowers over the Blessed One, gathered together, and spoke this verse:

"Whatever perceptions of vehicles we had before,
And likewise perceptions of fruits,
From those perceptions we are free;
We wholly devote ourselves to the awakening of a buddha."

Then many thousands of arhats, among them Śāriputra, Maudgalyāyana, Subhūti, Aniruddha, Revata, and Kapphiṇa, rose from their seats, bowed with joined palms toward the Blessed One, and said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, today our ill will is complete. Our intention is complete. We have vanquished the opposition of Māra. We are fully endowed with the five deeds of immediate retribution. Blessed One, today we are fully endowed with the five qualities of sense desire. Blessed One, today we are fully endowed with wrong views. Blessed One, today we are devoid of right view. Blessed One, today we have taken the lives of many hundreds of thousands of living beings. Blessed One, today we have attained awakening. Today we have passed completely into nirvāṇa in the element of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates."

Then the Blessed One, remaining silent, kept to equanimity.

Then many hundreds of thousands of living beings in that assembly fell into doubt, and they said, "What is this? What is this darkness into which we have fallen? If even arhats speak words like these, what need is there to mention ordinary beings?" Those who had fallen into doubt were unable to move from their seats: those who were sitting could not stand, and those who were standing could not sit. Fallen into doubt, they remained there, deeply pondering.

Then, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Ānanda knew with his mind the thoughts in the minds of those many hundreds of thousands of living beings, and he said to Mañjuśrī the youthful, "Mañjuśrī, having heard what those elders said, these many hundreds of thousands of living beings have fallen into doubt about what these elders had in mind when they spoke, and the Blessed One, too, remains silent. Mañjuśrī the youthful, please speak!"

When he had said this, Mañjuśrī the youthful said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, this belongs to the irreversible bodhisattvas. What these elders had in mind when they spoke these words is directly evident to those who are irreversible."

He said, "Mañjuśrī, are these elders, too, irreversible from awakening?"

He said, "Ānanda, it is so."

Ānanda said, "Mañjuśrī, since the Blessed One remains silent about what these elders had in mind when they spoke these words, please speak about it."

Mañjuśrī said, "Venerable Ānanda, 'mother' refers to the ignorance that gives birth to saṃsāra, and they have utterly destroyed that ignorance. Venerable Ānanda, 'father' refers to improper attention accompanied by the passion of delight. They are free of that improper attention, and the passion of delight, too, they have utterly destroyed. 'Arhat' refers to the qualities of ordinary beings, and they have demolished and destroyed them by way of not demolishing. Whatever perception of the qualities of ordinary beings they had, that too they have split apart by way of not dividing any phenomena. Whatever perception they had that had become a perception of the Tathāgata, that perception too has left them by way of nonarising. Venerable Ānanda, it was with this in mind that they said, 'Today we are fully endowed with the five deeds of immediate retribution.' Why? There is nothing removed and nothing taken up; therefore they are said to be endowed with the five deeds of immediate retribution.

"If you ask what they had in mind when they said, 'Today we are fully endowed with the five qualities of sense desire,' venerable Ānanda, they know these five qualities of sense desire to be like a dream, like an illusion, and like a mirage. In them that knowledge is complete, and they have made the five qualities of sense desire neither incomplete nor complete. Why? Because these are utterly nonexistent, and in that way they fully know them. In that way they are endowed with them. In that way their knowledge is complete, and therefore they are said to be fully endowed with the five qualities of sense desire. Ānanda, it was with this in mind that they said, 'Today we are fully endowed with the five qualities of sense desire.'

"Venerable Ānanda, as for their saying, 'Today we are fully endowed with wrong views; we are devoid of right view,' venerable Ānanda, they see all phenomena as wrong. Venerable Ānanda, 'wrong' means false: all phenomena are false. They are joined to nothing at all; like space, they are without dejection, without attachment, and without support. Why? All phenomena have as their essential nature the absence of entity, and they know them in that way. In reality all phenomena are equal, and that equality is right view. They are free of that perception of equality. Why? Awakening is free of all perceptions, and without apprehending even the subtlest particle of any phenomenon, they have attained and realized those qualities of a buddha. Venerable Ānanda, it was with this in mind that they said, 'Today we are fully endowed with wrong views; we are devoid of right view.'

"Venerable Ānanda, as for what they had in mind when they spoke the words, 'Today we have taken the lives of many hundreds of thousands of living beings,' venerable Ānanda, having heard this hidden speech of theirs, many hundreds of thousands of living beings and many hundreds of thousands of gods have known and realized all phenomena to be like an illusion, like a dream, and like an echo. Thereby, free of the perception of a being and the perception of a life, they have produced roots of virtue for awakening, in the manner in which no phenomenon is produced. Having heard this, other monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen, different from them, also became free of the perception of a being and the perception of a life, and therefore they too will not die. Why? If there is a perception of a being and a perception of a life, there will be death; but they become free of that perception through the nature of reality that is utterly unborn. Venerable Ānanda, it was with this in mind that they spoke the words, 'Today we have taken the lives of many hundreds of thousands of living beings.'

"Venerable Ānanda, as for what they had in mind when they spoke the words, 'Today we have attained awakening; today we have passed completely into nirvāṇa in the element of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates,' venerable Ānanda, many hundreds of living beings and many hundreds of thousands of living beings within this assembly have today understood the afflictions to be equal to the awakening of a buddha and have generated acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena. Therefore, having today triumphed over the afflictions for the sake of awakening, they said, 'Today we have attained awakening.' There is no abandoning of afflictions, and there is no teaching of the qualities of a buddha. In them there is not even the slightest affliction. Venerable Ānanda, it was with this in mind that they spoke the words, 'Today we have attained awakening; today we have passed completely into nirvāṇa in the element of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates.'

"'Today' means that this very day is called 'today.' Why? Venerable Ānanda, any son or daughter of good family who has generated the mind set on awakening has illuminated all phenomena. That being's generation of the mind set on an awakening not yet attained is a rising together with all phenomena. When he becomes free of the perception of awakening, then he sets together with all phenomena in the element of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates.

"Venerable Ānanda, for those of the bodhisattva vehicle, it is day by the perception of the noble ones. For the childish, it is day by the perception of the sun. Why? If day had truly become something with an essence, then days would become a heap. If they had truly become a heap with an essence, then nights too would become a heap, and the past days and nights would be mixed together. Day would become night, and night would become day.

"Venerable Ānanda, for the childish it is day by the perception of day, and night by the perception of night. For one of the bodhisattva vehicle who is cared for by a spiritual friend, there is no perception of day in the day and no perception of night in the night. Why? The wisdom of a buddha is free of all perceptions, and therefore it aspires to nothing as directly present."

Then, at that time, Mañjuśrī the youthful spoke these verses:

"Ignorance, which gives birth to saṃsāra,
Is what is called 'mother';
They have pulled it out, root and all;
Therefore it is said they have killed their mother.

Improper attention,
The passion of delight, is called 'father';
Just as it truly is,
They know it as forever without entity.

Truly without entity,
It is uprooted and not engendered again;
Unapprehended and without abode,
Therefore it is said to be killed.

What are spoken of as the qualities of an arhat,
And the separate qualities of the childish:
Since they have demolished craving,
It is said they have killed an arhat.

Whatever perception of the Saṅgha arose,
They know its nature;
That all phenomena are indivisible
Is taught with certainty by the word 'splitting.'

Whatever perception of a perfect Buddha
They had formerly conceived,
As unborn and unceasing,

That they have pulled out, root and all.

This perception of unbroken continuity,
As empty, and empty of middle and end,
They have expressed in words;
They have understood it as equality.

The five qualities of sense desire that are spoken of,
By whatever names they are designated,
Since they have realized perception as an illusion,
They are therefore free of perception.

These sense desires the monks
Have left undiminished, just as before;
And so, in the presence of the Protector of the World,
They spoke those words.

The phenomena of desire, like a dream,
They know to be empty;
Their knowledge of them as utterly unborn
Is perfectly complete.

As hollow, empty, and without core,
They fully know phenomena to be wrong;
And 'wrong' is said to mean false;
Their perception in this is perfectly complete.

All phenomena are false;
Nowhere do they truly mingle;
Like five fingers in space,
Since they do not exist, they do not truly mingle.

Whatever is spoken of as right,
That view they know;
With whatever the equality of phenomena is equal,
Their knowledge of the view is equal to that.

'Because beings are perceived, there is dying':
So those of childish mind imagine.
If beings are not apprehended,
Death cannot come to be.

The deeply baneful perception of a life,
Through which so very many people
Do not cast off the suffering they have taken on,
That perception they have removed.

They are free of the perception of beings;
They have demolished the perception of a life;
Therefore it is said that they
Have cut off the lives of many beings.

They have triumphed over all afflictions;
They have realized the nature of reality free of affliction;
They know awakening to be free of superimposition,
Unchanging, and utterly stainless.

They have defeated all the māras without exception;
They have purified the qualities of a buddha;
Because all phenomena are without discord,
Through nonarising they have passed into nirvāṇa."

As soon as Mañjuśrī the youthful had spoken these verses, those very many hundreds of thousands of living beings became free of doubt and uncertainty and also gained light on all phenomena. Each and every one of them offered his delight to Mañjuśrī the youthful and said, "Just as Mañjuśrī the youthful has now taught, so shall we too speak the Dharma, and so shall we teach it to beings."

Then the Blessed One said to Mañjuśrī the youthful, "Mañjuśrī, your fine explanation of those things that were said in hidden speech is excellent, excellent!"

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, those many hundreds of thousands of living beings who had fallen into doubt and uncertainty, and who have now been released from doubt and uncertainty, Ānanda, have been brought to maturity by Mañjuśrī the youthful, who caused them to take up awakening. They fully understand the Dharma he has taught."

Ānanda asked, "Blessed One, how is it? Are they irreversible from awakening?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, it is so. They are irreversible from awakening. Why? Because they have been taken in hand by the spiritual friend Mañjuśrī the youthful."

Ānanda asked, "Blessed One, how is it? Are all those monks, too, who rose up from the perceptions of the faith-follower, the Dharma-follower, and likewise the eighth, the stream-enterer, the once-returner, the non-returner, the arhat, the śrāvaka, and the pratyekabuddha, irreversible from awakening?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, this is hard to believe. Those who are inclined toward the inferior, the lazy, those who indulge in sensual things, those who delight in busyness, those whose mindfulness lapses, those without vigilance, those who are not in meditative equipoise, those whose minds are confused, those gripped by conceit, those who guard their bodies, those who guard their lives, those who hold views about body and life, the stingy, those of bad character, the malicious, those without faith in the qualities of a buddha, those of corrupt wisdom, those who have fallen into the hands of bad friends, those who are not cared for by a spiritual friend, those who have abandoned the Perfection of Wisdom, those who hold objectifying views, those intent on gain, those intent on honor, those attached to alms bowls and robes, those who do not strive at yoga without sleeping in the first and last watches of the night, those who speak falsehood, those who use divisive words, those who use harsh words, those who engage in idle chatter, the covetous, those full of malice, those with wrong views, those busied with any sort of entanglement, those who go about on errands as messengers, those who engage with signs, and those without faith or inclination toward all the phenomena that are emptiness, signlessness, wishlessness, nonformation, nonarising, nonceasing, and imperishability: Ānanda, for those possessed of such qualities, it is hard to have faith in this matter.

Then the Blessed One, having spoken thus, fell silent. Then, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Ānanda said to Mañjuśrī the youthful, "Mañjuśrī, why does the Blessed One let the time pass in silence?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Venerable Ānanda, in the future, in the last five hundred years of that later time, most beings will be possessed of such qualities, and they will not have faith. That is why the Blessed One lets the time pass in silence."

He said, "Mañjuśrī, who are those who will have faith in this?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Venerable Ānanda, those who will have faith are few. Venerable Ānanda, it is like this: for example, the beings who are skilled in the meaning are very few, while those who are unskilled are exceedingly many. Why is that? Because they do not practice it, and therefore they are not skilled in it. Venerable Ānanda, in the same way, the beings who have faith in this

teaching of the Dharma are very few. And those who do have faith will not always be held in honor; rather, they will be utterly cast out by villages, cities, towns, provinces, and the circles of royal palaces. Why is that? Because in the past they committed deeds, the obscuration of their own karma, that cause them to be deprived of the Dharma."

He said, "Mañjuśrī, please speak for the sake of those very ones whose faith will be slight."

Mañjuśrī said, "Venerable Ānanda, ask the Blessed One, and the Blessed One will answer you."

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, please explain it for the sake of those sons and daughters of good family whose faith will be slight. When they have heard it, they will rejoice."

Then the Blessed One looked out in the four directions and covered the great trichiliocosm with his tongue. From that tongue he sent forth light, and that light pervaded world systems as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges, illuminating them with a great radiance. Then, through the power of the Buddha, that fourfold assembly saw, in world systems in the east as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges, the buddha blessed ones teaching this very teaching of the Dharma, and they heard that teaching of the Dharma as well. In the same way, in all ten directions, they heard this very teaching of the Dharma, with nothing added and nothing missing. Having heard it, they gathered together and made this request to the Blessed One: "Just as the Blessed One has taught, so we see these countless, innumerable buddha blessed ones also teaching this very teaching of the Dharma, with nothing added and nothing missing. Therefore, may the Blessed One please expound this very teaching of the Dharma and this very talk on the Dharma without interruption." Such was their request.

Then the Blessed One drew back his tongue and said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, does a tongue such as this speak falsehood?"

He replied, "No, Blessed One, it does not. Therefore, may the Blessed One please explain it for the sake of those sons or daughters of good family whose faith will be slight. Then even those who lack faith will be brought to faith by those who have been won over."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, this entire fourfold assembly now gathered here, and all the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, and gandharvas who have heard this

teaching of the Dharma, are irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. When they too have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, they will teach this Dharma discourse in this very place, with nothing added and nothing missing, just as I teach it now."

Then that fourfold assembly and the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, and gandharvas were satisfied, delighted, and overjoyed; filled with great gladness, joy and happiness of mind arose in them. Some scattered garments over the Tathāgata, and some scattered flowers, garlands, and ointments. The women took off all the ornaments from their bodies and scattered them in the direction where the Blessed One was. Having scattered them, they all gathered together and spoke these words: "The tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, speak without duplicity."

Then the Blessed One again said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, it is just as these women have said. The tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, speak without duplicity; they are without attachment, without aversion, without delusion, and without stain. Therefore, hearing the buddha blessed ones is never fruitless."

He asked, "Blessed One, what is this that is called hearing the buddha blessed ones?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, do you not know?"

He replied, "Blessed One, I do not know."

The Blessed One said, "Then listen, Ānanda, and I shall explain."

He said, "May the Blessed One please explain."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, all those who hear my name, Śākyamuni, will become irreversible from awakening. Why is that? Ānanda, since awakening is without attachment, without aversion, and without delusion, and so is never fruitless, what need is there even to mention those who offer a single flower to the Tathāgata, or those who scatter a single flower upon the relic stūpas of the Tathāgata who has passed into parinirvāṇa?"

He asked, "Blessed One, will beings born in the animal realm who hear it also become irreversible from awakening?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, for any who hear the name Śākyamuni, that very hearing will become for them a seed of awakening. Ānanda, if hearing the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, were not fruitful, then

the tathāgatas would not be ones who speak without duplicity."

"Ānanda, what do you think of this? How big is the seed of a nyagrodha tree in whose shade a hundred, or two hundred, or three hundred, or four hundred, or five hundred living creatures may sit?"

He replied, "Blessed One, its seed is small."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, does that nyagrodha tree, once it has sprung from so small a seed, gradually grow, thrive, spread out, and become broad?"

He replied, "Blessed One, that is so."

He said, "Ānanda, just as that nyagrodha tree, once it has sprung from a small seed, gradually grows, thrives, spreads out, and becomes broad, in the same way, Ānanda, the seed of hearing the sound 'Śākyamuni' will also gradually bring about unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. It will not go to waste, it will not utterly go to waste, and it will not rot. Why is that? Ānanda, this seed of all phenomena is without any abiding, and therefore it will not utterly go to waste. Ānanda, this seed of all phenomena is imperishable, and therefore it will not go to waste. Ānanda, this seed of all phenomena is without clinging, and therefore it will not rot."

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, what is this? Is it the Blessed One's former aspiration, or is it the very nature of things that hearing the buddha blessed ones is fruitful?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, I did make this aspiration: 'May whoever hears my name become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.' And moreover, this is also the nature of reality of the buddha blessed ones. Why is that? Ānanda, all the buddha blessed ones are equal and the same in all qualities."

He asked, "Blessed One, if the buddha blessed ones are equal and the same in the nature of reality, why then do they make aspirations?"

He said, "Bodhisattvas who have not heard this sublime Dharma make aspirations, and through that aspiration they will quickly come to hear this teaching of the Dharma."

He said, "Blessed One, those who possess such qualities as these act for the benefit of many beings. How wondrous it is, the extent to which the buddha blessed ones possess such vast qualities!"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, so it is. That is to say, for the sake of buddhahood I acted for the benefit of many beings. Ānanda, my buddhafield is not one possessed of the five degenerations. Ānanda, in the past I attended upon and served the buddha blessed ones, had no regard for body or life, gave away everything I owned, and was free of avarice; and, having undertaken great diligence, without abiding in any phenomenon, I benefited all beings; and because I declared no phenomenon at all, I truly accomplished awakening."

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, it is wondrous that Māra, the Evil One, makes no obstacle to this teaching of the Dharma."

He said, "Ānanda, he has not heard it. Why is that? Because Mañjuśrī the youthful blessed it beforehand, and so he makes no obstacle."

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful withdrew that blessing. The very moment Mañjuśrī the youthful withdrew the blessing with regard to Māra, the Evil One, then, in no more time than a dream, Māra, the Evil One, heard the sound of the Irreversible Wheel, and he also heard the name of Śākyamuni. Then Māra, the Evil One, frightened, terrified, and panic-stricken, his hair standing on end, cried out, "All my victories are becoming no victories! All my domains are becoming no domains!" And he grieved and wailed. Through his grieving and wailing he took on an aged and decrepit form: just as a man who has reached a hundred years grows old and decrepit, so his form grew old.

Then Māra, the Evil One, with his fourfold army, together with all the gods of Māra's class there are in the great trichiliocosm, went to where the Blessed One was, in an array just like the one at the time when the Blessed One attained awakening. When Māra, the Evil One, came into the presence of the Blessed One, he appeared aged, decrepit, and worn out: just as a man who has reached a hundred years walks with his body bent forward, leaning on a staff, so it was that Māra, the Evil One, came before the Blessed One. When he had arrived, the gods stationed in the sky proclaimed to his fourfold army a sound such as this: that by hearing the sound of the Irreversible Wheel and the name of Śākyamuni, one attains irreversibility. And having heard it, all those fourfold armies were checked and fell into doubt, and they no longer followed Māra, the Evil One.

Then Māra, the Evil One, alone and without a companion, went before the Blessed One and said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, I am alone and

without a companion, aged, decrepit, and worn out, with no one even to lift me up by the hand. All my victories have become no victories, and all my domains have become no domains. Since the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, is loving toward all beings, may the Blessed One please show love to me. Since there is no one apart from the Blessed One himself who will grant me protection, please have compassion for me."

When he had made this plea, the Blessed One said to Māra, the Evil One, "Evil One, the realm of beings is vast. Evil One, even if buddha blessed ones as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges were to appear in the world every single day, still, Evil One, they could not exhaust the realm of beings."

When he had said this, Māra, the Evil One, said to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, though the realm of beings is vast, I have become alone and without a companion, and there is no one at all to lift me up by the hand. Blessed One, since I go wandering along the road leaning on a stick, Blessed One, please give me relief. Blessed One, please give me relief in such a way that I may be joyful, that I may quickly become wholly joyful, and that I may have a large following."

When he had made this plea, the Blessed One said to Māra, the Evil One, "Evil One, go with an easy heart. Evil One, all those, however many they may be, who do not come to trust this Dharma discourse will become your supporters and companions."

Then Māra, the Evil One, was satisfied, delighted, and overjoyed; filled with great gladness, joy and happiness of mind arose in him, and he spoke these words: "I shall bless beings thoroughly in such a way that they have no faith in this Dharma discourse and fall into doubt. If they come to doubt, they will come under my power."

Then Māra, the Evil One, again said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, please give me further relief, so that I may be more joyful still. Let the Blessed One not proclaim aloud what he has declared, namely, 'All those, however many, who hear my name, Śākyamuni, will become irreversible.' Blessed One, please remain silent. Please give me relief in such a way that beings will not undertake diligence to accomplish the vehicle of the buddhas, and will not abide in awakening."

When he had made this plea, the Blessed One said to Māra, the Evil One, "Evil One, go with an easy heart. I shall act in such a way that no being whatsoever

is established in awakening. I shall not move any being whatsoever from the realm of beings: I shall act in such a way that no being whatsoever is moved from form, and likewise from feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness.

"Evil One, go with an easy heart. I shall act in such a way that no being whatsoever moves from the view of the perishable collection, that no being whatsoever moves from apprehending form, that no being whatsoever moves from the sixty-two views, that no being whatsoever moves from perceiving the past, or from perceiving the future, or from perceiving the present, and that no being whatsoever moves from killing, from taking what is not given, from sexual misconduct, from lying, from divisive speech, from harsh speech, from idle chatter, from covetousness, from malice, or from wrong view.

"Evil One, go with an easy heart. I shall not let any being whatsoever take up generosity. I shall not let them take up moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration, or wisdom.

"Evil One, go with an easy heart. I shall not move any being whatsoever from grasping at beings as beings, or from clinging to beings as beings. I shall not move them from perceiving a father, from perceiving a mother, from perceiving a brother, from perceiving a sister, from perceiving a wife, from perceiving a son, from perceiving a daughter, from perceiving day, from perceiving night, from perceiving a month, or from perceiving a half month.

"Evil One, go with an easy heart. I shall not move any being whatsoever from the perception of generosity, the perception of moral discipline, the perception of patience, the perception of diligence, the perception of meditative concentration, the perception of wisdom, the perception of the awakening mind, the perception of the powers and the fearlessnesses, the perception of the faculties, the strengths, and the factors of awakening, the perception of the path, the perception of the Buddha, the perception of the Dharma, the perception of the Saṅgha, the perception of the Saṅgha of the Buddha, or the perception of the Buddha as omniscient.

"Evil One, go with an easy heart. I shall act in such a way that no being whatsoever is moved from any phenomenon, and that no being whatsoever is let take up any phenomenon."

Then Māra, the Evil One, was delighted and overjoyed. Joy and happiness of mind arose in him, he was freed from the thorn of sorrow, and on that very spot he became youthful again. Then he scattered flowers over the Blessed

One, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and spoke this verse:

"The Tathāgata, supreme in the world,
The perfect Buddha, does not speak otherwise;
He does not speak words that turn out otherwise.
Today joy has arisen in me."

Then Māra, the Evil One, having spoken this verse, went away from the Blessed One's presence with an easy heart. Then, when Māra, the Evil One, had reached his own abode, he was endowed with the five qualities of divine sense pleasure and gained mastery over them, and he amused himself, delighted, and enjoyed himself fully; and he no longer gave rise to any thought of harm.

When this teaching on the sending back of Māra was being explained, the great earth shook in six ways.

The fifth fascicle.

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, why did this great earth shake in six ways?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, it is because, when this teaching on the sending back of Māra was being explained, six million four hundred thousand living beings attained acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena."

He asked, "Blessed One, are there perhaps some here who have fallen into doubt about it?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, a hundred million living beings have fallen into doubt and uncertainty, thinking, 'What is this? What sort of thing is this? Have we not heard otherwise elsewhere?' And thinking, 'How could we ever be happy? How are we to abide? From where have we come?', they do not even know which direction is which, and they stare at one another."

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "So that there may be no doubt about what was spoken and with what intention, may the Blessed One please quickly make it clear to these beings. The Blessed One said, 'Evil One, go with an easy heart. I shall act in such a way that no being whatsoever is established in awakening. I shall act in such a way that no being whatsoever is moved from the realm of beings,' and so on, applied in full as before, up to, 'Evil One, go with an easy heart. I shall act in such a way that no being whatsoever is moved from any phenomenon, and that no being whatsoever is let take up any phenomenon.' With what intention did the Blessed One say

this? Blessed One, please quickly make it clear to these beings. Blessed One, so that light may be shed for the people of later times, for the sake of those who will take up this Dharma discourse, master it, recite it, and keep it, please explain with what intention the Blessed One spoke as he did."

Then, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

"Awakening has no abiding;
Awakening is nowhere cut off.
Therefore I said that I
Would not establish beings in awakening.

"All beings and awakening,
And likewise I myself, have no abiding.
With this in mind I said
That beings have no abiding in awakening.

"From the realm of beings, in any way at all,
No being is to be moved,
For any existing thing therein
Is never apprehended at all.

"This realm of beings, by its very nature,
Is empty and inconceivable.
Even those endowed with omniscience
Cannot move it from this.

"A being is nothing but the aggregates;
The aggregates and nirvāṇa are not two.
With this in mind
I said that no being whatsoever is moved.

"That which is grasped and so set moving:
In it no grasped thing is established.
By its essential nature it does not move:
Understand the aggregates in this way.

"The aggregates are unmoving and single,
Without a being, without intrinsic nature,
Forever wholly without support;
Know them to be without abiding.

"The aggregates are just like space.
As for this domain of the aggregates,

Where there is no domain, as their domain
The aggregates are taught to be like space.

"What is spoken of as the element of space
Is unborn; it is not born.
In truth the aggregates are equal to it;
They cannot be moved.

"The perishable collection, or any knowable phenomenon,
Is not truly apprehended at all.
'It is not space, and it is not moved':
That is what I said in words.

"The mind of beings, as something firmly abiding,
Is never at all apprehended.
Both the object and minds
Are by essential nature without movement.

"Whatever the sixty-two views may be,
Whatever phenomena seem distinct,
They are, in just this way,
Like reflections in water.
Know the sixty-two views always
To be like an optical illusion.
Because they are selfless and insubstantial,
By essential nature they do not move.

"Perception of the past and the future,
And likewise of what arises in the present:
This perception is insubstantial,
Like the water of a mirage.
This perception is selfless;
In it there is no being.
Where there is no being,
That cannot be moved.

"Beings who have taken life,
Who have entered the great wilderness:
To bring them wholly to nirvāṇa,
There is no power that can move them from this.
If they were apprehended anywhere at all,

Then they could be moved in that way;
Because there are no beings,
It is said they are not to be moved.

"Awakening is spoken of as 'not given':
Never is it given to anyone at all.
Therefore whoever strives in this
Cannot be moved.

"What embodied beings have not given
Is the gift, the inconceivable gift of Dharma.
Therefore whoever strives in this
Cannot be moved.

"Whoever, knowing that in what is called sexual misconduct
There is in truth nothing wrong at all,
Strives in this way,
Cannot be moved.

"The foremost one who undertakes diligence
So that people who persist in speaking false words
May be liberated,
Cannot be moved.

"Whatever is divisive or harsh in speech,
And whatever is idle chatter,
All of it is like an illusion,
Hollow, forever without substance.
Its ground or its abiding place
Never exists at all.
Know sound to be like an echo;
It, too, has no abiding.

"Whatever covetous thought has arisen in him,
Marked by attachment to self,
That self he has fully understood;
Therefore he cannot be moved.

"Whoever knows that malice by its nature
Has no defining characteristic, and that awakening too
Has just that as its characteristic,

Cannot be moved.

"Whoever, fully understanding wrong view,
Has discerned clearly through right view,
And has passed beyond all reckoning,
Cannot be moved.

"The wise do not have young women
Given away as gifts;
Giving away the young is deeply wrong;
This is no illumination.

"The moral discipline that, through wrong view,
Casts aside the noble path:
One seeking the noble path here
Does not lead anyone into that.

"The many kinds of patience that exist
Among the non-Buddhist outsiders (tīrthikas) beyond this teaching
Are held to be neither patience that follows the path
Nor a means of joining with nirvāṇa.
The endurance of striving in the five fires
And the like among heterodox tīrthikas
Does not bring the attainment of awakening;
Therefore the wise do not strive in it.

"Here, the outsiders who hold to signs,
And all their domains of concentration,
Are censured by the buddhas;
Therefore he does not lead anyone into them.

"Whatever wisdom is bound up with desire,
He does not lead anyone into it,
For that knowledge does not accomplish
The inconceivable wisdom of the buddhas.

"The fearless bodhisattva,
The one who gathers beings,
That intelligent one cannot be moved
From gathering beings.

"Because of clinging to the perception of beings,
The awakening mind is spoken of here.
That awakening is without clinging;
It cannot be moved.

"Father and mother and brothers,
Sisters, sons, and relatives:
All are said to be like illusions;
They cannot be moved.

"All those various things:
The perception of them all is insubstantial.
A phenomenon that has no substance
Cannot be moved.

"Whatever perception there is of day and night,
Whatever of a month or of a half month,
All those perceptions are without attachment,
Just like the water of a mirage.

"Whatever perception has arisen
Of generosity, moral discipline, patience, diligence,
Meditative concentration, wisdom, the awakening mind,
And of the powers and the fearlessnesses,
And whatever has arisen concerning the faculties,
The factors of awakening, and the paths,
Knowing that it has arisen from unknowing,
The wise do not set it in motion.

"Whatever perception of the Buddha, perception of the Dharma,
Or perception of the Saṅgha has arisen,
One who abides firmly, free of all diversity,
Is not to be moved from it.

"Those who have no perception of the Buddha or the Saṅgha,
Those who have no perception of the Omniscient One,
Make the awakening of the buddhas,
Inconceivable awakening, far distant.
So that awakening might not become distant,
Here, therefore, before the Evil One,
I spoke these words:
'They will not be moved from this.'

"All phenomena and all beings,
Every one of them, just as they are,
I set forth plainly; but the Evil One,
Through his evil understanding, did not realize it."

As soon as the Blessed One had explained this teaching on the sending back of Māra, those hundred million living beings were freed from doubt and gave up uncertainty; they attained illumination regarding all phenomena and attained acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena. The moment they attained that acceptance, they all gathered together and spoke these verses:

"The path of the Buddha is inconceivable;
We clearly understand the supreme path.
The Guide who cuts through uncertainty,
The Blessed One, is our Teacher.

"We have attained illumination everywhere;
We abide well on the path of the Buddha.
All the directions have become illumined,
And we see koṭis of buddhas.

"The nature of reality, which never
Abides in form, we too come to see.
Thus have our eyes
Been purified by the Guide, the Protector of the world."

Then those hundred million living beings, having spoken these verses, each scattered garments as an act of offering to the Blessed One and to this Dharma discourse, and spoke these words: "May this Dharma discourse resound in the ears of all beings!"

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, those who, as soon as they hear this Dharma discourse that teaches the sending back of Māra, have faith and trust in it and give rise to no doubt: Blessed One, how much merit will they generate?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, suppose a son or daughter of good family were to respect, honor, venerate, and make offerings to a hundred buddhas in the morning, a hundred buddhas at midday, a hundred buddhas in the evening, a hundred buddhas in the first watch of the night, a hundred buddhas at midnight, and a hundred buddhas in the last watch of the night, serving them with every comfort and with everything that lets them dwell in ease, and

were to serve them in this way for twenty thousand years. Ānanda, what do you think of this? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?"

He replied, "Much, Blessed One. Much, Sugata. Blessed One, it is not easy even to give an example of it."

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, a son or daughter of good family who, as soon as they hear this teaching on the sending back of Māra, has faith and trust in it and gives rise to no doubt, will generate much merit."

Then three sons of good family of the bodhisattva vehicle came through the sky, through the open air, bearing many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of māndārava flowers, towering high like Mount Meru. The venerable Ānanda and the entire assembly saw those sons of good family of the bodhisattva vehicle coming from far away, and when they saw them, they were filled with wonder.

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, where have these bodhisattvas come from?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, eastward from this buddhafield, beyond as many world systems as there are sands in the river Ganges, there is a world system called Lotus Towering Like Meru. There they heard this Dharma discourse, and for that reason they have come here from that world system."

Then those three sons of good family of the bodhisattva vehicle took their places before the Blessed One and scattered and strewed those māndārava flowers over the Blessed One. Having scattered and strewed them, they spoke these words: "Blessed One, we have faith and trust in this Dharma discourse, and we have no doubt. Why is that? Because, just like the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, we too have no uncertainty whatsoever."

Then one of those sons of good family of the bodhisattva vehicle said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, if those who speak truly were to speak of a 'Tathāgata,' that Tathāgata is I, for I have no uncertainty about this Dharma discourse and entertain no doubt."

The second son of good family of the bodhisattva vehicle said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, if those who speak truly were to speak of a 'Blessed One,' that Blessed One is I, for I have no uncertainty about this Dharma discourse and entertain no doubt."

The third son of good family of the bodhisattva vehicle said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, if those who speak truly were to speak of a 'Buddha,' Blessed One, that Buddha is I, for I have no uncertainty about this Dharma discourse and entertain no doubt."

Then many hundreds of thousands of living beings in that assembly thought, "Since it is impossible for two buddhas ever to arise in the world at the same time, why do these speak like this?" They became distracted and grew uneasy on their seats.

Then, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, how is this? Are those really the names of these three, that they proclaim things in this way, as though roaring a lion's roar?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, the name of the first of these is Rightly Engaged by Uttering the Word 'Tathāgata.' The name of the second is Rightly Engaged by Uttering the Word 'Blessed One.' The name of the third is Rightly Engaged by Uttering the Word 'Buddha.' Ānanda, that is how it is. There is a reason why these speak in this way, and those, moreover, are their names."

Ānanda said, "Blessed One, may those who became distracted come to understand that these three spoke as they did after reflecting on this, and may their roots of virtue become even more brightly luminous. For example, Blessed One, if a little boy, a youth whose complexion is perfectly pure, were also bathed in red sandalwood water, his body would become even more fragrant, perfectly pure in complexion, and radiant. In the same way, Blessed One, so that the roots of virtue of those bodhisattvas who are skilled in veiled speech may become even more brightly luminous, may the Blessed One please explain to the many hundreds of thousands of living beings who became distracted what these three have said in veiled speech."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses:

"Past, present, and future
Are like suchness itself.
Because he sees all phenomena in that way,
He is called 'Tathāgata.'

Whatever phenomena are present, past,
And yet to come,
They are not two, indivisible into two,

Forever utterly without characteristics.

Just as the buddhas of the past
Gave inconceivable gifts,
So these have given gifts in that same way;
Having reflected on that, he said this.

He has entered awakening without attachment;
Just as the tathāgatas of the past did,
So he has entered awakening.
Therefore he is called 'Tathāgata.'

Having entered into all phenomena,
He seeks peaceful awakening,
Yet he does not apprehend even that awakening.
Therefore he is called 'Tathāgata.'

He speaks just in the manner of those of the past;
So too of those yet to come;
And as those of the present attain, so does he.
Therefore he is called 'Tathāgata.'

Just as the steadfast ones, lords of compassion for living beings,
Showed patience in the past,
So he is steadfast in patience
And abides at the farthest shore of patience.

Just as I exerted myself in diligence
In the past, when I was seeking awakening,
So he has become diligent.
Therefore he is called 'Tathāgata.'

The sameness of all phenomena that I touched,
That sameness he has touched,
And in him there is no conceit whatsoever.
Therefore he is called 'Tathāgata.'

All phenomena are free of conceit;
By their essential nature they are always the same,
Without conceptualization, nothing at all.
He knows that sameness.

Like the tathāgatas of the past,
He too has realized likewise the meditative absorption
That is nonconceptual and peaceful.
Therefore he is called 'Tathāgata.'

The intrinsic nature of all phenomena,
Which I have fully proclaimed,
Is forever utterly without entity.
That intrinsic nature he knows.

Through wisdom he has gained the defining mark.
By fully knowing the emptiness of phenomena,
He fully knows all phenomena
And has reached the far shore of wisdom.

Just as the inconceivable wise ones of the past
Reached the far shore of wisdom,
Yet did not even reach its end,
And, not having arrived, did not pass into nirvāṇa,

Just as those who reached the end of suchness
Did not arrive at its end,
So he too has not found it.
Therefore he is called 'Tathāgata.'

He does not apprehend awakening
In the way that others imagine it.
Because he does not apprehend any phenomena,
He is called 'Tathāgata.'

Just as awakening is free of attachment,
So he has attained nonattachment.
Being unattached to all phenomena,
He realizes the awakening that is free of attachment.

The path that none of the childish have practiced,
Whose essential nature they do not know,
Just as the protectors, lords of the world,
Cultivated it in the past,
So he cultivates
That undefiled, supreme path.

That beginningless path
He fully knows to be empty.
The nature of reality of the noble path,
Which is sameness and without beginning,
With that he makes himself the same.
Therefore he is called 'Tathāgata.'

As the path is, so is awakening;
And just as awakening is,
So he fully knows the body to abide.
Thus he is called 'Tathāgata.'

The word 'Tathāgata' itself,
In brief, is a name for the Dharma.
Those who have no doubt about this,
Those wise ones have entered awakening.

Ānanda, having reflected on this,
He proclaimed it in words.
What he said is just so;
This is the domain of the wise.

The irreversible bodhisattva,
Who is called wise, is fearless.
Whatever has been fully proclaimed,
All of it is his domain.

This explanation, Ānanda,
Of why that fearless, intelligent one
Is called 'Tathāgata'
Is taught to bodhisattvas."

Ānanda asked:

"Blessed One, what is the explanation
By which you have said
That the intelligent one is fearless?
And what are those dharmas like?"

The Blessed One said:

"The inconceivable awakening of the buddhas,
Which they accomplished
Over hundreds of koṭis of eons

And over many koṭis of eons:
Just so, for the sake of beings,
He accomplishes awakening and abides well,
And in this he has no fear.
Therefore he is called 'Blessed One.'

He has no fear of saṃsāra;
He abides firmly even within saṃsāra
And awakens beings from it.
Therefore he is called 'Blessed One.'

How is it that he has no fear there?
How does he abide firmly in saṃsāra?
O unsurpassed protector of the world,
How does he release beings?

He does not make phenomena increase,
Nor does he destroy even the slightest thing.
Because there is no increase and no destruction,
He releases beings from suffering.

Thus he has no fear of saṃsāra,
Thus he abides firmly in existence,
Thus he liberates beings.
Therefore he is called 'Blessed One.'

Whatever the dharmas of a buddha are,
He fears none of them, without exception.
Those dharmas, infinite and boundless,
He proclaims to beings.

"Knowing all the dharmas of a buddha, without exception,
To be dharmas empty of essential nature,
He accomplishes those dharmas,
Yet sees nothing in them.

Holding in reverence, in this way,
That phenomena are empty of essential nature, he meditates.
Knowing them to be empty in every respect,
He accomplishes them without fear.

Fully knowing all phenomena
To be false, he is not daunted.
Having become fearless,
He teaches the true characteristic of phenomena.

He has utterly passed beyond all fears
And has completely abandoned all the lower realms.
Without fear or terror,
He draws embodied beings out of the lower realms.

From saṃsāra, with its great terrors,
He frees countless beings.
He does not move beings out of it,
And yet he frees them from it.

Having freed them, though he establishes them
On the plain of nirvāṇa, supreme peace,
He does not apprehend those beings.
Therefore he is called 'Blessed One.'

Though he teaches embodied beings
Dharmas that are like space,
He has no fear in this.
Therefore he is called 'Blessed One.'

All the manifold dharmas
He proclaims without distinction.
They are equal through the equality of awakening,
And he does not apprehend even that awakening.

So that people may accomplish awakening,
He leads others into this.
Though he teaches dharmas in this way,
He has no fear of anything at all.

Through teachings of many kinds
He sets these embodied beings free.
He is free of fear and without grasping.
Therefore he is called 'Blessed One.'

He has truly attained the cessation of perception;
The bodhisattva is without afflictions.
Therefore he has gained this name

And is renowned as 'Blessed One.'

One beyond reproach who is seeking,
Since he has already fully known
That phenomena are the same as cessation,
He too is called 'Blessed One.'

The intelligent one does not cling to names;
He has no attachment to names.
In order to free them from attachment to names,
He teaches the Dharma to embodied beings.

The awakening that the wise have entered
Is free of names.
Beings who cling to names
Are very far from awakening.

Sounds, like echoes,
Perish in every way.
Knowing sounds to be nonexistent,
He is not attached even to 'they are equal.'

He is unattached to all sounds
And does not dwell in expressions.
Because he is free of elaboration for the sake of awakening,
He is called 'Blessed One.'

Such dharmas as these,
Of which the word 'Blessed One' is spoken,
The bodhisattva has not found.
Therefore he is called 'Blessed One.'

The steadfast one who has entered awakening,
Free of attachment and undefiled,
Fully knows this explanation
And is not attached to it in any way.

This explanation spoken in the word 'Blessed One,'
And the others too,
Knowing these, he says,
'I am a buddha, a blessed one.'

Ānanda, having reflected on this,
He said, 'Whoever speaks truly of the Blessed One
Speaks of me in so speaking.'
That is why he spoke as he did."

Ānanda asked:

"Blessed One, having fully understood which teachings
To bodhisattvas does this steadfast one
Say, 'I am a buddha'?
What is that explanation?"

The Blessed One said:

"Because he has realized all phenomena, without exception,
To be utterly nonexistent,
And because he has realized phenomena to be pure,
He is called 'Buddha.'

One who knows the afflictions to be false,
Does not come under their power,
And is unattached to all afflictions
Is called 'Buddha.'

When he knows the body to be empty,
This is not mine, nor anyone's;
In truth, in this body,
No core can be apprehended.

The childish, unskilled regarding the body,
Take what has no core to be a core.
He realizes it exactly as it is.
Therefore he is called 'Buddha.'

Whatever has become
The perception 'I' is utterly without characteristics.
Knowing it to be without characteristics,
He does not come under its power.

He knows form to be unborn at the prior limit
And never to have truly arisen.
It is imagined by the childish;
There is nothing established in it.

He realizes feeling to be rootless;
He does not apprehend a root in it.
Since he does not abide in any phenomena,
For him there is no feeling.

Having realized that perception is like a mirage,
Without substance and without entity,
He therefore does not engage
With any phenomena in any way.

All bodies are without a core;
Nothing is grasped by formations.
Having realized that the body is empty of formations,
He is not attached to the body.

The formations and the body as well
Are like the core of a plantain trunk.
He realizes this exactly as it is;
Thus he is called 'Buddha.'

In truth, consciousness
Does not abide inside the body,
Nor is consciousness possible
Outside this body.

In all phenomena, in every way,
Consciousness is not possible.
Its abode, its lack of abode,
And its transference are not apprehended.

He thus understands consciousness
To be forever utterly without entity.
Like a magical emanation or an illusion,
No one ever knows it.

No being whatever, in any way,
Sees consciousness as it is.
In truth, no one at all
Has come to know it.

All phenomena are without entity;
In truth there is no knowing.
Here neither phenomena nor beings,

As they are imagined, exist even within.

All phenomena are without entity,
Unchanging and free of elaboration.
He realizes them to be like emanations.
Therefore he is called 'Buddha.'

Having realized all these phenomena,
He abides as the buddhas abide.
He does not abide in any phenomena.
Therefore he is called 'Buddha.'

Just as phenomena abide,
So he understands them as suchness.
Buddha and awakening are alike,
Unapprehendable and unconditioned.

As for the generation of the mind
By which one has set out for the sake of awakening,
Since not even the subtlest phenomenon is apprehended,
That mind does not become an object of apprehension.

"Since he has generated that mind
For the sake of awakening,
He realizes that awakening and mind are the same,
Like something made by illusion.

Ānanda, having reflected on this,
He proclaimed in words,
'The one who is called Buddha,
The buddha, the guide, is I.'

The dharmas taught by the word 'Buddha'
Are like these.
Those who abide in this Dharma
Have set out for supreme awakening.

Those who know dharmas in this way
Are close to supreme awakening.
They have no doubt whatsoever
About any phenomena.

Those who come to know this Dharma,
Spoken after reflecting in this way,
Because they have abandoned uncertainty,
Will become the best in the world."

As soon as the Blessed One had given this answer, teaching the three called Tathāgata, Blessed One, and Buddha, those many hundreds of thousands of living beings said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, concerning what the Blessed One intended in calling the bodhisattvas 'Tathāgata,' 'Blessed One,' and 'Buddha,' we are now without doubt and entertain no uncertainty. Blessed One, we understand those dharmas completely. By way of not apprehending any phenomena, we have regained our mindfulness here. The Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha has done for us what a father and mother do. The Blessed One has stretched out his hand to us. We will not again give rise to a wavering mind; we have attained the Dharma that is without wavering. Blessed One, just as, for example, no one can make unwavering space waver, in the same way, Blessed One, we too are without wavering with regard to all phenomena. Why is that? Because we realize that all phenomena are without wavering, equal to and like space, and unborn."

Then those many hundreds of thousands of living beings bowed their heads at the Blessed One's feet, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and sat down not far from the Blessed One.

Then the bodhisattva great being Smiling Serene Faculties spoke these verses at that time:

"Many who perceived results
You have freed from perceiving results.
You who have attained the perfect result,
Protector of the world, I bow to you.

You speak of the results,
And you also proclaim sameness.
Buddha, perfect in result,
Wise one of the world, I bow to you.

There is no being who desires a result.
Perfect Buddha, who frees those
Whose domain is the various results,
Leader of the world, I bow to you.

You have fully entered sameness
And you also teach all dharmas.
You know all beings to be the same;
In sameness, I bow to you.

Beings who fix on results as objects
You have fully freed from fixing on objects.
You who release from every object of fixation,
Renowned in the world, I bow to you.

Perfect in the result that is utter peace,
Having wholly abandoned the various results,
Endowed with every virtue without exception,
Knower of the world, I bow to you."

Then, having praised the Blessed One with these verses, the bodhisattva great being Smiling Serene Faculties bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, withdrew from the Blessed One's presence, and sat down a short distance away. There he remained, gazing at the Blessed One without blinking, with joy and supreme delight.

Then the bodhisattva great being called Padmaśrīgarbha rose from his seat, scattered lotuses over the Blessed One, and praised the Blessed One with these verses:

"Many beings who dwell in the perception of things
You have set free.
Free of timidity, without grasping,
Supreme sage, I bow to you.

You teach the Dharma
That pacifies existence and is free of existence.
Hero, you who are free of existence,
Supreme sage, I bow to you.

You know things to be empty,
Forever without essential nature.
Perfect Buddha who has abandoned existence,
Supreme sage, I bow to you.

You have truly cut off what leads to existence;
Without afflictions, you abide nowhere.
Fully liberated from fear and terror,

Supreme sage, I bow to you.

Without timidity, free of diffidence,
You proclaim the sublime speech.
You have passed beyond all sounds.
Supreme sage, I bow to you.

Free of sorrow, you have attained fearlessness,
And you fully pull out the thorn of sorrow.
You have abandoned Māra and are without faults.
Supreme sage, I bow to you."

Then, having praised the Blessed One with these verses, the bodhisattva great being Padmaśrīgarbha said this:

"In the later time, in the final age,
Those wise ones who are not frightened
By such a sūtra as this,
Those beings are worthy of homage."

Then the bodhisattva great being called Dustless Intellect said to the Blessed One:

"This sūtra teaches with certainty
The vast Dharma of the buddhas.
Those who have no doubt
About it will be few.

Through clinging to the perishable collection,
Perceiving as body what is not body,
The childish, wholly bound to perceptions,
Speak ill of it when it is explained.

Beings whose devotion Māra has turned back,
And those under Māra's sway,
Those who have no devotion
To such a sūtra as this, are unwise."

Then the bodhisattva great being Utpalanetra said to the Blessed One:

"Those gentle ones who have no doubt
About such a sūtra as this
Are equal to the eye of the world,

And they also bestow the eye."

Then the bodhisattva great being Devoted to Stūpas said to the Blessed One:

"Those gentle ones who have devotion
For such a discourse as this
Are like stūpas for the world;
They will become supreme among humans."

Then the bodhisattva great being Ever Longing said to the Blessed One:

"Those who uphold this
Turn their backs on this body;
No desire arises in them, they are unattached
To any phenomena, and free of doubt."

Then the bodhisattva great being Devoted to Garments said to the Blessed One:

"Those who are free of doubt about this way,
Those beings will be wrapped all around
With incense, with many koṭis
Of garments, and with flowers."

Then the bodhisattva great being Giver of Food said to the Blessed One:

"To those who are free of doubt about this way
I shall give, without exception,
The finest divine foods,
As many as there are, with a hundred flavors."

Then the bodhisattva great being Rightly Engaged in Compassion on Seeing Beings said to the Blessed One:

"Those base ones who doubt
This unsurpassed sūtra,
Those beings are objects of compassion;
Hereafter they are Māra's due.

Those who doubt such a sūtra as this
Even for a single moment,
Those beings will go to the hells
And will remain long in the hells.

Those who do not understand this way
Are companions of evil friends.
They are unskilled in this profound teaching,
Wholly covered by the net of delusion.

Those who, with poor understanding, look for faults,
Or, through attachment to gain and honor,
Reject this teaching,
Do so because of their bad character.

Those with no devotion to awakening,
Lazy, who have abandoned diligence,
Devoted to the lesser, with corrupt wisdom,
Will not have devotion to this.

Those who always delight in saṃsāra,
Who are under the sway of eternalist views,
And who cling to the three worlds,
Will not have devotion to this.

Those who babble, foolish and of poor understanding,
Greedy for sensual pleasures and unskilled,
Who always delight in bustle,
Are the ones who reject it.

Attached to robes and alms bowls,
Always greedy for food,
With a meager share of the white dharmas,
These are the ones who reject it.

Beings who desire results
And cling to results
Find it hard to understand here
The intent of the savior, the protector of the world."

Then the bodhisattva great being Wholly Abandoning Evil Friends said to the Blessed One:

"Those who reject this sūtra,
Which frees from the perception of results,
Those beings are to be shunned
Like excrement, urine, and utter rot.

Those who reject this Dharma
Are to be shunned in this way:
Like a stinking corpse,
They are to be utterly abandoned.

For example, when a dull-witted man hears
That robbers, raiders of villages,
Are lurking in the wilderness,
He flees, thinking, 'They will come into view.'

Just so, those who reject this sūtra,
Bewildered by delusion,
Utterly wicked and of poor understanding,
Hearing of it, flee, thinking, 'We will come to see it.'"

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, it is amazing how utterly refined in understanding these sons of good family are. Blessed One, how is this? Do they speak these words through having generated the power of meditative absorption, or do they speak in this way through the power of the Buddha?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, they speak in this way through the power of the Buddha. These sons of good family have also attained the generation of the power of meditative absorption with respect to this Dharma discourse, and they have also attained nonattachment. Why is that? Ānanda, just as these sons of good family have now heard it from me, so they heard this Dharma discourse, exactly this much, with nothing added and nothing missing, from sixty koṭis of buddhas. Recollecting it, they speak in this way through generating the power of meditative absorption and through the power of the Buddha. Why is that? Ānanda, what these have said is just so; it is directly evident to them."

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, how much merit will a son of good family or a daughter of good family generate who, as soon as they hear this Dharma discourse, has devotion to it and entertains no doubt?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, suppose a son of good family or a daughter of good family who has rightly set out for unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening were to fill this Jambudvīpa with jewels and present them as an offering to the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas. One who, as soon as they hear this Dharma discourse, has devotion, faith, and

conviction and does not doubt it will generate far more merit than that. Ānanda, leave aside Jambudvīpa filled with jewels. Ānanda, suppose someone were to fill as many world realms as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges with jewels and present them as an offering to the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas. One who hears this Dharma discourse and, having heard it, as soon as they hear it, has devotion, faith, and conviction and does not doubt it will generate far more merit than that."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses at that time:

"Compared with one who fills this Jambudvīpa
With jewels and makes an offering
To the tathāgatas, the saviors,
The buddhas, the protectors of the world,

The wise one who hears this sūtra
And has exceptional devotion to it,
That one endowed with devotion
Will generate more merit than that.

Compared with one who fills with jewels
Fields as many as the Ganges' sands
And offers them to the buddhas,
This is more excellent than that."

The sixth fascicle, the last.

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, how much merit will a son of good family or a daughter of good family generate who, having devotion to this Dharma discourse and understanding it, takes it up, bears it in mind, reads it, masters it, or recites it?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, suppose a son of good family or a daughter of good family who has rightly set out for unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, apart from this Dharma discourse, were to give gifts to the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas for a hundred eons; apart from this Dharma discourse, were to guard moral discipline for a hundred eons; apart from this Dharma discourse, were to practice patience for a hundred eons; apart from this Dharma discourse, were to exert diligence for a hundred eons; apart from this Dharma discourse, were to enter into the attainments of the meditative concentrations for a hundred eons; and apart

from this Dharma discourse, were to cultivate wisdom for a hundred eons and become skilled in the affairs of the world. Ānanda, that person would not have shown honor to the Tathāgata."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses at that time:

"One who for a full hundred eons
Serves the Tathāgata
With food and everything else
Does not thereby show him reverence.

One who upholds this sūtra,
Which destroys fixation on results,
Has shown honor to the buddhas
And has shown honor to the Dharma.

The perfect buddhas are the Dharma body,
Born of the Dharma, bearing the banner of the Dharma;
This is honor to the buddhas,
And so he has honored the buddhas.

Those who for a full hundred eons
Make offerings of robes and the like
To the tathāgatas, the buddhas,
Have not thereby honored them.

But if one upholds this way,
Then one honors the buddhas.
This is the supreme among honors;
Giving many robes is not like this.

Those who for a full hundred eons
Scatter incense and flowers
Before the buddhas, protectors of the world,
Have not thereby honored them.

One who upholds this sūtra
Of the profound and supreme way
Shows the sublime honor
To the saviors, the protectors of the world.

Though one were to build a stūpa
For the protector of the world from precious materials,
Making it like Mount Meru,

One would not thereby have honored the Buddha.

One who upholds this sūtra
And does not even regard himself as upholding it
Offers the supreme service,
Supreme among all offerings.

A person who for a full hundred eons
Guards moral discipline
But does not uphold this sūtra
Has no supreme discipline.

One who upholds this sūtra
And has no conceit about upholding it,
That discipline is praised;
That discipline is unsurpassed.

Because he has fully upheld this way,
The wise one seeks that discipline
Which is great discipline,
Inconceivable and immeasurable.

For one who trains in this sūtra
As I have taught it, seeing sameness,
There is neither moral discipline
Nor bad conduct.

One who does not train in this sūtra
Does not train for awakening.
Awakening and training are the same;
No one has ever trained in it.

One who upholds this sūtra,
The discipline taught in this sūtra,
Such discipline of theirs
Will become perfect discipline.

A person endowed with patience
Who here, for a full hundred eons,
Endures from all beings
Harsh words and abuse,

Whose mind does not change
Even when his hands and feet are cut off,
Who nowhere gives rise
To hostility or anger,

That person who speaks of patience,
Even should he spend koṭis of eons
In patience of that kind,
That patience is not praised.

One who hears this sūtra
And upholds it with devotion,
That is the supreme patience;
That is patience most excellent.

One who upholds this sūtra
And is attached to nothing at all,
That patience is especially exalted;
That patience is unsurpassed.

One who desires the supreme wisdom of the buddhas,
The wisdom free of attachment,
Should swiftly take up this sūtra
Without attachment to it.

Compared with one who for a full hundred eons,
Endowed with diligence, never sits down,
Not overcome by sleep, self-possessed,
Always passing his time this way,

If a wise one applies himself to this sūtra
In order to receive its transmission,
That diligence is superior to the other;
This diligence is especially exalted.

One who for a full hundred eons
Becomes a sage with the five superknowledges
But does not listen to this sūtra
Is not called supreme in superknowledge.

One who, knowing the meaning, without abiding anywhere,
Upholds this sūtra
Has the supreme superknowledge

Among all superknowledges.

A person who for a full hundred eons
Is endowed with wisdom,
Endowed with worldly wisdom,
Certain in the affairs of the world,

If he does not train in this way,
Does not know the way of wisdom.
One who upholds this way,
That hero truly has wisdom.

One who hears this sublime sūtra
And has devotion to it and understands it,
That steadfast one has wisdom;
He is learned in wisdom.

Whoever wishes in any way
To know all phenomena through wisdom
Should receive the transmission of this sūtra;
He will attain this wisdom.

What is fully taught in this sūtra
Is the domain of wisdom.
Therefore exert yourselves with diligence
To take up this sūtra."

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One:

"Running a full league, or even a hundred leagues,
One should listen to this sūtra,
Which dispels the manifold fruits of karma.

Crossing a full league
Heaped to the brim with burning embers,
The wise should swiftly go
To wherever this sūtra abides.

Whatever meditator seeks meditative concentration
In the highest of all concentrations
Should receive the transmission of this sūtra,
Which dispels all afflictions.

Whoever wishes to go
To the world realm renowned as Abhirati,
That realm of surpassing beauty,
Should expound this sūtra.

Whoever wishes to see the Buddha Akṣobhya,
The unsurpassed Sage,
Should receive the transmission of this sūtra,
Read it often, and uphold it.

Whoever wishes to go to Sukhāvatī,
The abode of bodhisattvas,
If he receives the transmission of this sūtra,
Will go there very swiftly.

By reciting this sūtra
Spoken by all the buddhas,
One will see the perfect Buddha Amitābha,
The inconceivable.

Bodhisattvas beyond reproach,
Who long for these qualities,
Should uphold this sūtra
Spoken by all the buddhas."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Excellent, Ānanda, excellent! Ānanda, it is just as you have said. Ānanda, whenever a son of good family or a daughter of good family reads or recites this sūtra with a mind free of all mental distraction and all signs, at that time they will see whatever buddha they wish to see. But if, being distracted, they do not read it or do not recite it, then at the time of death they will not see the buddhas, the blessed ones, before their eyes. Why is that? Ānanda, the son of good family or daughter of good family who receives the transmission of this Dharma discourse, or upholds it, or recites it, or reads it, will be embraced by all the buddhas."

Then the maiden Siṃhā, together with five hundred maidens, joined her palms toward where the Blessed One was, bowed, and said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, if one who has become a woman receives the transmission of this sūtra, or upholds it, or recites it, or reads it, what qualities will come of it?"

The Blessed One said: "Siṃhā, if a woman who has truly set out for unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening receives the transmission of this Dharma discourse, or upholds it, or recites it, or reads it, or bears it, then her very state of being a woman will be her last. Why is that? Because by receiving the transmission of this Dharma discourse, upholding it, reciting it, bearing it and reading it, the female afflictions, those afflictions through which a woman takes on the state of a woman, will not arise in that woman."

When he had said this, the maiden Siṃhā said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what are those female afflictions, possessing which a woman takes on the state of a woman?"

The Blessed One said: "Siṃhā, here a woman sees another woman who is fair of form, beautiful, lovely to behold, decked with ornaments, and at ease, and she generates desire for that. If she does not consider, 'This is a lump of filth painted with colors, a seducer of the childish, foul-smelling, smeared with filth,' then, not considering it in this way, she sees it as attractive, and by generating desire for it the woman takes on the state of a woman.

"Moreover, Siṃhā, here a woman becomes jealous, miserly and deceitful. She says one thing in words while her mind is carried off elsewhere; she says one thing openly in words while secretly thinking another; she goes to a monk for the sake of enjoyment and not for the sake of the Dharma; she is overcome by anger, by dullness and by much sleep; she delights in busy company; she does not seek to receive the transmission of a Dharma discourse such as this; and she spends her days and nights with an afflicted mind rather than a purified mind. Through these afflictions that woman takes on the state of a woman and does not bring it to an end.

"Therefore, Siṃhā, in brief, so that none of her afflictions may arise or occur, a woman should receive the transmission of this Dharma discourse, should recite it, should master it, should uphold it and should read it. Why is that? Because this Dharma discourse is free of the female afflictions."

The maiden Siṃhā said: "Blessed One, if a woman does not wish to be transformed from the state of a woman, yet receives the transmission of this Dharma discourse, upholds it, recites it, bears it, reads it and masters it, how should that be regarded?"

The Blessed One said: "Siṃhā, even though she may not wish to be transformed from the state of a woman, if she receives the transmission of this Dharma discourse or reflects on it, it should be known that this is her last state

as a woman, except when it is a display of miraculous power.

"Siṃhā, suppose, for example, that some man or woman were to hurl their own body into a great mass of fire, spreading everywhere, blazing and full of flames, and were to say these words: 'May my body not be burned! May the color of my skin not change!' Siṃhā, what do you think? By saying those words, would that man or woman obtain that wish?"

She said: "No indeed, Blessed One. Blessed One, a great mass of fire has the very nature of burning, and it destroys the color of the skin."

The Blessed One said: "Siṃhā, in just the same way, this Dharma discourse dispels all afflictions."

"Therefore, Siṃhā, a woman who does not want the state of a woman, who wishes swiftly to accomplish the qualities of a buddha, who wishes to see countless buddhas, and who wishes to attain unobstructed eloquence, should uphold this very Dharma discourse, should master it, should recite it, should read it, should bear it, and should learn it by heart."

Then the maiden Siṃhā, together with the five hundred maidens, joined her palms and said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, we received this Dharma discourse from the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Dīpaṃkara, and ever since then we have given it to many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of living beings to uphold."

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how is this? Has the maiden Siṃhā not been transformed from the state of a woman?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, do you think that the maiden Siṃhā is a woman?"

He said: "Blessed One, that is so."

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, do not say that. Why is that? Ānanda, this is a miraculous display of the maiden Siṃhā and these five hundred maidens. Having seen the people of later times, the maiden Siṃhā has shown this miraculous display out of compassion for women, and in order to free women from the state of a woman. Why is that? These women enter all the households which men do not enter and have no right to enter, and there they train women by means of miraculous display. Ānanda, in the maiden Siṃhā there is no quality of a woman and no quality of a man. Why is that? Because no phenomenon whatever is apprehended, she does not apprehend a woman

and does not apprehend a man. The maiden Siṃhā has fully realized and understood this Dharma discourse; she has attained illumination. Therefore, Ānanda, a woman who wishes to follow the training of the maiden Siṃhā should uphold this Dharma discourse, should master it, should recite it, should bear it, should read it, and should learn it by heart."

Then five thousand nuns rose from their seats, joined their palms toward where the Blessed One was, bowed, and said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, from this day onward we will uphold this Dharma discourse, master it, recite it, bear it, read it, and learn it by heart. Why is that? Blessed One, we do not seek the state of a woman. Blessed One, we despise the state of a woman. Blessed One, from this day onward, until we have mastered this Dharma discourse, we will not lie down to rest, and we will not let ourselves be overcome by dullness and sleep."

When they had said this, the Blessed One said to those nuns: "Sisters, you have spoken these words well. You have put on the great armor, and in order that you should in no way seek the state of a woman but should seek the qualities of a buddha, you have undertaken this great diligence. Excellent, excellent! Therefore, exert yourselves with even greater diligence to uphold this Dharma discourse."

When those nuns heard this, they were satisfied, elated and delighted; they rejoiced greatly, and joy and gladness arose in them. Each of them spread her upper robe over the feet of the Blessed One, and having spread them, they spoke this verse:

"For the sake of the state of a man,
Today we have found relief.
Since the Victor does not speak otherwise,
We shall become supreme in the world."

Then five hundred wives of householders, hearing this verse of those nuns, rose from their seats, joined their palms toward where the Blessed One was, bowed, and said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, from this day onward we too will uphold this Dharma discourse, master it, recite it, bear it, read it, and learn it by heart. From now on, may we never again fall under the power of others, never have to look to the faces of others, and never be made to keep company with them. May we never again carry a child in the womb for nine or ten months. Why is that? Blessed One, once one has become a woman, even if she is born into a royal household, she falls under the power of others and

must wait upon a husband for as long as she lives. Blessed One, from this day onward, until we die, we will exert ourselves with diligence. We will undertake to eat only a single meal a day. We will not give up our resolve. Until we have made this Dharma discourse dwell within our very bodies, we will not allow even our husbands to take us by the hand."

The Blessed One said: "Daughters of good family, you have spoken these words well. Excellent, excellent! From now on you will not fall under the power of others. You will not have to look to the faces of others. You will not carry a child in the womb for nine or ten months. You will be born in a buddha field where there are no women."

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what is the name of the world realm in which these sisters will be born?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, the world realm in which they will be born is called Appearing Like a Precious Lotus."

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what is the name of the tathāgata who dwells in that world realm?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, there dwells the tathāgata called Appearing to Scatter Precious Jewels for All Beings, and he teaches the Dharma. Even as these wives of householders recite this Dharma discourse, they will see him."

When those laywomen, the wives of householders, heard this, they were satisfied, elated and delighted; they rejoiced greatly, and joy and gladness arose in them. They untied from their necks ten thousand pearl necklaces adorned with precious jewels and scattered them over the Tathāgata, strewing them all about. Having scattered them, they spoke these verses:

"In the transformation of the state of a woman,
Today we have found relief.
The Buddha does not speak otherwise;
He has declared it in words of truth.

This body of afflictions, so very evil,
This body of a woman, we shall abandon.
Not knowing things truly as they are,
The childish, and even the learned, are deluded.

From now on, for us, the dwelling in the womb
Will no longer be a great terror.
Since we have obtained supreme virtue,

We are free of the dwelling in the womb."

When those wives of householders had spoken these verses, they gazed at the Blessed One with unblinking eyes and bowed to him.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, scattered divine flowers over the circle of the Blessed One's assembly and said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, I have taken up this Dharma discourse. Blessed One, I have mastered this Dharma discourse."

The Blessed One said: "Kauśika, because of that, from now on you will not have to enter the battlefront of the gods and the asuras."

Then, in order to bring to fulfillment the roots of virtue of many hundreds of thousands of living beings, Mañjuśrī the youthful said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, for as long as I had not set this Dharma discourse turning, the Tathāgata had not set his mind on awakening."

The Blessed One said: "Mañjuśrī, because of that you appear throughout the ten directions and have become supreme among many koṭis of niyutas of bodhisattvas, just like the disk of the sun."

Then, at that moment, this great earth shook in six ways, and the whole circle of the assembly was covered with divine flowers knee-deep.

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what is the cause, and what is the condition, for this shaking of the great earth that has occurred in the world? And who has scattered these flowers?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, many koṭis of niyutas of gods heard what Mañjuśrī the youthful explained, and with joyful minds they scattered these flowers. Having scattered them, they spoke these words: 'We too uphold this Dharma discourse. We master it. We recite it. We bear it. May we too become just like Mañjuśrī the youthful!' No sooner had they spoken these words than this Dharma discourse became manifest to them, and all of them, satisfied, elated and delighted, bowed at my feet and at the feet of Mañjuśrī the youthful. Then this shaking of the earth occurred."

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this Dharma discourse possesses great qualities. Blessed One, this Dharma discourse possesses marvelous and wondrous qualities. Blessed One, those beings within whose hearing this Dharma discourse resounds are not possessed of meager roots of virtue."

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, so it is; so it is. Those sons of good family or daughters of good family who listen to this Dharma discourse and, having heard it, are devoted to it, have faith in it, uphold it, master it, recite it, and bear it, have attended upon many buddhas. They are freed from every fall into the lower realms and bad destinies, and from every birth in the unfavorable states. They have conquered Māra, the Evil One. They have raised aloft the banner of the Dharma. They have set the lamp of the Dharma fully ablaze. They have dispelled the blinding darkness. They have reached the seat of awakening. Ānanda, those who, as soon as they hear this Dharma discourse, are devoted to it, uphold it, master it, recite it, and bear it, are close to me. Ānanda, those who uphold this Dharma discourse, master it, recite it, bear it, and read it are my children, born from the Dharma body. Each of them wishes to eat the food of the Tathāgata. Each of them wishes to sit at the foot of the tree of awakening, just as I now sit there. Each of them wishes to teach the Dharma, just as I now teach it."

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, in later times, in a later age, will there be some who are devoted to this Dharma discourse, who uphold it, master it, recite it, bear it, retain it, and read it?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, those who are devoted to it now will be devoted to it in later times. Those who uphold it now will uphold it in later times. Those who read it now will read it in later times. Ānanda, that someone who has not heard this Dharma discourse now should hear it in later times, this I do not see anywhere in the world with its gods, its māras and its Brahmās, among the generations of beings with their ascetics and brahmins; that is not possible. Ānanda, those whose wealth this is now, it will also be their wealth in later times.

"Ānanda, suppose, for example, that here some householder or householder's son were rich, of great wealth, of great means, with much property and many possessions, and that he buried treasures as a hoard and went away to another country. Ānanda, what do you think? As soon as he comes back, will he find what he buried as a hoard?"

He said: "Blessed One, he will find it. Why is that? Because that wealth is his very own."

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, in just the same way, those whose wealth this is now, it will also be their wealth in the future, and just as I now distribute it,

they too will distribute this unsurpassed wealth of the Dharma to others."

"Ānanda, those who in later times will be devoted to this Dharma discourse, who will uphold it, master it, recite it, bear it, and read it, I see with the eye of a buddha just as though they were present now. Those who will reject it I also see."

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what kind of destiny will befall those who are not devoted to it, who reject it, who speak ill of it, and who disparage it?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, what is the use of your asking this? Be silent!"

The venerable Ānanda said: "Blessed One, please explain. Then even those who are not devoted and have no faith will become devoted and will understand."

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, whatever is the destiny of one who has committed the five acts of immediate retribution, that will be their destiny. Ānanda, what do you think? If someone were to take the lives of all the beings in a great trichiliocosm, what kind of destiny would befall him?"

He said: "Blessed One, he is a wicked one."

The Blessed One said: "It should be known that that is the destiny of such a person. Ānanda, if someone were to destroy the stupas of buddhas, blessed ones who have passed into complete nirvāṇa, as many as the grains of sand of the river Ganges, and were also to burn them with fire, would he, on that basis, generate much demerit?"

He said: "Much, Blessed One! Much, Sugata! On that basis he would generate much demerit; it cannot be equaled, it cannot even be contemplated."

The Blessed One said: "It should be known that that is the destiny of such a person. Ānanda, if someone were to bring about the cessation of the way of the Dharma of the buddhas, the blessed ones, of the past, the future and the present, what kind of destiny would befall him?"

He said: "Blessed One, he is a wicked one; it is not easy to put into words."

He said: "It should be known that that is the destiny of such a person."

The venerable Ānanda said: "Blessed One, further, if someone turns other beings away from it, what kind of destiny should be understood for him?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, if someone were to gouge out the eyes of all the beings in a great trichiliocosm who possess the ten virtuous paths of action and have truly set out for unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, what kind of destiny would befall him?"

He said: "For many eons he would be born blind, and he would also experience feelings of suffering, burned by the fire of the hell beings."

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, I instruct you, and you should understand this: whoever turns even a single being away from this Dharma discourse, it should be known that that is his destiny."

The venerable Ānanda said: "Blessed One, if a bodhisattva who has set out for unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening has doubts about this Dharma discourse but does not reject it, how will it be with him?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, for as many thoughts of doubt as he gives rise to, for so long he will fail to please the buddhas. For that many eons he puts awakening far off."

He said: "Blessed One, further, if someone has been devoted to it and has understood it, and then comes to have doubts, how large will be the body with which he experiences suffering?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, what is the use of your asking about his body? Be silent!"

He said: "Blessed One, these four assemblies will be terrified, and the people of later times, when they hear of it, will also be terrified; therefore please explain."

The Blessed One said: "The body with which he experiences suffering will measure ten thousand leagues."

The venerable Ānanda said: "And the one who did not guard his words, what will his tongue be like?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, his tongue will measure a thousand leagues, and it will be plowed by a hundred million plows. A hundred million iron balls, blazing and fiercely ablaze, will burn upon it. Why is that? Because he did not in any way guard his words."

Then those four assemblies were terrified and their hair stood on end. With tears streaming down their faces and with weeping countenances, they fell to the ground then and there. Having fallen, they all spoke with one voice:

"Blessed One, we are filled with remorse for the sake of any son of good family or daughter of good family who, by speaking such words, will experience such a bodily form."

Then other beings there, tears streaming down their faces, wept and spoke these words: "Blessed One, whatever doubts we have given rise to in this life and in other births, Blessed One, calling as witnesses also all the other tathāgatas we have seen, we wish to confess that karmic obscuration individually in the presence of the Tathāgata. We wish to renounce it individually. Since we confess the transgression as a transgression and see the transgression as a transgression, may the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, accept our transgression."

The Blessed One said: "Sons of good family, it is excellent, excellent, that you see the wrong as a wrong, and confess it and renounce it. Sons of good family, this confession made after seeing a wrong as a wrong brings growth in the Dharma and Vinaya of the noble ones."

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, will those in this assembly who have given rise to doubt also, Blessed One, go to such a hell?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, those here who have given rise to doubt, since they have confessed and renounced it, will find that what they must experience becomes slight."

The venerable Ānanda said: "Blessed One, how slight will what they must experience become?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, at the time of their death they will experience the sufferings of the hell beings. From each and every pore of their skin countless, immeasurable feelings will arise; and this is said only in brief. Why is that? Because they have in some measure confessed individually before me and before countless other buddhas, blessed ones.

"Therefore, Ānanda, a son of good family or a daughter of good family should generate devotion to this Dharma discourse, thinking, 'My body too might come to be like this; I too might come to experience feelings like these.' And having become devoted, they should be free of hesitation and free of doubt. One who has not forsaken the Tathāgata, who has not forsaken the tathāgatas of the past, the future and the present, who has not forsaken the Dharma, who has not forsaken the Saṅgha, and who has not forsaken the way of the

Dharma of the buddhas, the blessed ones, of the past, the future and the present, should be devoted to this Dharma discourse, should uphold it, should master it, should recite it, should bear it, and should read it."

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, when the buddhas, the blessed ones, give the teaching of the Dharma of the irreversible wheel, with what in mind did the Blessed One speak of 'one who has not forsaken the Saṅgha'? What is it that the Tathāgata has designated as the Saṅgha?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, the Tathāgata has designated the irreversible as the Saṅgha."

He said: "Blessed One, yet those irreversible bodhisattvas are not themselves inclined toward the irreversible Saṅgha, nor are they counted among it."

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, all those who from the depths of their hearts have given rise to the mind set on awakening, and who do not subsequently perceive even that mind, are truly inclined toward the irreversible Saṅgha. All of them are counted among the irreversible Saṅgha."

The venerable Ānanda said: "Blessed One, how greatly the buddhas, the blessed ones, are endowed with skill in means! It is wonderful how, through skill in means, they have fully taught this meaning."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, scattered divine māndārava flowers over the Blessed One, and having scattered them, he said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, may all beings too teach the Dharma with this skill in means!"

The Blessed One said: "Kauśika, all those who become devoted to this Dharma discourse will teach the Dharma with this skill in means, just as I do now."

Then many thousands of gods scattered divine flowers over the Blessed One and spoke these words: "Blessed One, may all beings too obtain this Dharma discourse!"

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "For the sake of the people of later times, may the Blessed One please bless this Dharma discourse."

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, even if a son of good family or a daughter of good family who has gone out into the middle of the ocean should seek to listen to this Dharma discourse, they will without doubt come to hear it. Why is that? Ānanda, this Dharma discourse has been blessed by the buddhas of the

past."

He said: "Blessed One, although this Dharma discourse has been blessed by the buddhas of the past, may the Blessed One also bless it now."

Then the great earth shook in six ways: it shook, and it shook violently. Before the Blessed One there appeared a great lotus of Jambu River gold with many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of petals, illuminating all the ten directions with its light. And that light illuminated world realms as many as the grains of sand of the river Ganges. Then those four assemblies saw that before every one of the buddhas, the blessed ones, as many as the grains of sand of the river Ganges, in those world realms, there had appeared a great lotus of Jambu River gold with many hundreds of thousands of petals, illuminating all the ten directions with its light.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, in the guise of a householder, gave flowers of many different kinds to those four assemblies and spoke these words: "Scatter them as an offering to those tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, and to this Dharma discourse! Scatter them!"

Then those four assemblies took the flowers and scattered them over those tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, and they saw the flowers remain as parasols directly above the heads of those tathāgatas.

Then those four assemblies said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this shaking of the great earth that has occurred, and this great lotus that has appeared before the Blessed One and before these tathāgatas, of whom are they the portent?"

The Blessed One said: "Friends, this is the sign of the blessing of this Dharma discourse. Know by this sign that this Dharma discourse is blessed."

The venerable Ānanda said: "Blessed One, this Dharma discourse has been blessed."

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, so it is. This Dharma discourse has been blessed."

He said: "Blessed One, how is it? Was it blessed by the Blessed One alone, or was it also blessed by these tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, this Dharma discourse has been blessed by all the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas."

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, what is the name of this Dharma discourse? How should it be remembered?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, therefore remember this Dharma discourse as Not Clinging to Results. Remember it also as Free from the Various Results. Remember it also as The Teaching on Those Who Follow by Faith, Those Who Follow the Dharma, Those of the Eighth Stage, Those Who Go from Family to Family, Stream-Enterers, Once-Returners, Non-Returners, Arhats, Śrāvakas, and Pratyekabuddhas. Remember it also as The Teaching on Sending Māra Back. Remember it also as The Teaching of the Tathāgatas, the Blessed Ones, the Buddhas. Remember it also as Endowed with the Six Perfections. Why is that? Ānanda, if someone has faith in this Dharma discourse, retains it, reads it, or masters it, their cultivation of the six perfections will be brought to completion."

Ānanda asked, "Blessed One, how is the cultivation of the six perfections brought to completion for one who has faith in this Dharma discourse, retains it, reads it, or masters it?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, when sons or daughters of noble family have faith in this Dharma discourse, that is their perfection of generosity. That they have no doubt about this Dharma discourse is their perfection of moral discipline. That they accept and welcome this Dharma discourse is their perfection of patience. That their minds are not daunted by this Dharma discourse is their perfection of diligence. That their minds do not become distracted from this Dharma discourse is their perfection of meditative concentration. That they do not conceptualize this Dharma discourse, and do not see any phenomenon at all, is their perfection of wisdom. Ānanda, therefore remember this Dharma discourse as Endowed with the Six Perfections. Remember it also as The Teaching Given Alike by All the Buddhas. Remember it also as The Irreversible Wheel, the Teaching of Great Wisdom."

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, if even hearing the name of this Dharma discourse is so, what need is there to speak of its beginning, middle, and end?"

The Blessed One said, "So it is, Ānanda, so it is."

The venerable Ānanda asked, "Blessed One, by how many eons will one who hears the name of this Dharma discourse have cut short their time in saṃsāra?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, whoever hears the name of this Dharma discourse, The Irreversible Wheel, the Teaching of Great Wisdom, and having heard it comes to have faith in it, will have cut short their time in saṃsāra by a thousand eons."

The venerable Ānanda asked, "Blessed One, how should we regard one who, having faith in this Dharma discourse, generates the mind set on awakening?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, for whoever, having faith in this Dharma discourse, generates the mind set on awakening, that very act is their prophecy to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening."

Then, before each of the four assemblies, there appeared lotuses of various colors, of many colors, of countless colors, each with many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of petals. Then those four assemblies, satisfied, delighted, and elated, overjoyed and filled with joy and happiness, took up those lotuses and scattered them over the Blessed One. Having scattered them, they spoke these words: "We too shall teach this Dharma discourse in just that way. We shall explain it in detail in just that way."

Then at that moment the Blessed One smiled. As soon as the Blessed One smiled, all the musical instruments sounded without being played. The fragrance of every kind of incense arose. Many hundreds of thousands of gods scattered over the Blessed One divine sandalwood powder, divine gold dust from the Jambu River, divine māndārava flowers, and divine garments.

Then the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "The tathāgatas do not smile without a cause and without a condition. Blessed One, what is the cause of your smile? What is the condition?"

The Blessed One said, "Ānanda, all these four assemblies, and the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, and gandharvas who have heard this Dharma discourse, and all those who will hear it in a later time, will teach this Dharma discourse without omission or addition, just as I teach it now."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda, those four assemblies, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This concludes the noble Great Vehicle sūtra called The Irreversible Wheel.

It was translated, edited, and finalized by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra, Dānaśīla, and Munivarma, and the chief editor-translator, the monk Yeshé Dé, and others.

Translator's Notes

• The name of the attendant bodhisattva, sgra snyan, is translated by meaning ("Sweet Sound"), as its Sanskrit form cannot be identified with confidence; likewise the names of the eastern tathāgata, his world system and the three absorptions are given in English. In the Sanskrit title, vaivarta stands for avaivarta, "irreversible," as the Tibetan title shows.
• In the passage on Ānanda's foot, the second term, byed pa, is unclear in context; it is rendered generally as "nor was it affected in any way." In the second description of the water, bsngo ba ("dedication") is read as sngo ba, "blue," as in the first description. Here the tathāgata's name has khyab pa ("pervaded") for khebs pa ("covered"); the same name is kept.
• The phrase rendered "filled with clear blue water" reads literally "filled with water and clear dedication" (□□□□□□); this makes no sense here, and I read it as □□□□□, "blue," a likely copyist's slip. Likewise "the whole of" in Ānanda's report renders □□□□□, which is unclear as written; the sense of extent is taken from the parallel line spoken by the monks ("the whole of Prince Jeta's Grove").
• "The eighth-ranked one" renders □□□□□□□ (Skt. aṣṭamaka), the candidate for stream-entry, counted eighth when the noble persons are reckoned downward from the arhat. Here the earlier "clear blue water" is spelled □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, confirming the reading adopted in the previous piece. "Veiled speech" renders □□□□□□□□□□ (Skt. saṃdhābhāṣā), speech with a hidden intention.
• "Make this request of the Tathāgata" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□, literally "obtain the request"; the sense of an exhortation to make the request is clear from context. "Koṭīniyutas" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□, a stock vast number. "Does not regard as real" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ (Skt. na samanupaśyati), "does not observe," a standard Prajñāpāramitā idiom for not reifying.
• "Without an expanse" renders □□□□□□□□□□ in the verse; the corresponding prose speaks of all beings being equal "in the expanse of cessation," and the verse may reflect a variant or slip, but it is translated as it stands. "He is gentle" takes □□□□□□□ as a form of □□□□□, "gentle, tamed." "The second fascicle" renders the division marker □□□□□□□□□□□□□.
• "The ground of the lineage" renders □□□□□□□□□□ (Skt. gotrabhūmi), the stage of entering the noble lineage that precedes the eighth-ranked one in the traditional list of stages. "The eight wrong states" and "the eight right states" render □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ and □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ (Skt. mithyātva, samyaktva), the inverse and the factors of the eightfold path. "The transitory collection" renders □□□□□□□□□ (Skt. satkāya), the aggregates taken as a self.
• "The eighth" (aṣṭamaka) is the Abhidharma term for the candidate for stream-entry, the eighth counting down from arhatship; this sūtra reapplies it to the irreversible bodhisattva. In the first sentence the written □□□□□□ makes no sense; it has been read as □□□□□□, "has entered." The phrase "the loving-kindness that has not attained the emptiness of all dharmas and the element of peace" follows the negative □□□□□ as written; it may mean a love that does not settle into the peace of nirvāṇa. The "eight wrong ways" and "eight right ways" are the eight wrong factors and the eight factors of the noble path.
• "The eighth" and "stream-enterer" are the first stages of the Śrāvaka path, here reinterpreted for the irreversible bodhisattva; "the three fetters" are the view of the transitory collection, doubt, and holding moral discipline and ascetic practice as supreme, which the prose takes up in turn. The verse line "Thinking of it as one's own body, one generates a view even about the Victor" is rendered literally; its sense is that conceiving the Buddha as a bodily self is itself a wrong view.
• "The eighth," "stream-enterer" and "once-returner" are Śrāvaka stages that the sūtra

reinterprets for the irreversible bodhisattva; the verses state that they were taught with a hidden intention for those inclined to lesser vehicles. "Comes here" plays on the once-returner's single return to this world. The verse line rendered "For him there are no signs" reads □□□□□□□□□, which does not construe well; the sense has been taken from the parallel prose ("to demolish all signs").

• "Free of nourishment" renders □□□□□□□□□□, alluding to the four nourishments (āhāra) that sustain existence. "Demolished even the Buddha" follows the Tibetan; the sense, as the next sentence explains, is that he no longer observes a Buddha as an entity. The stages "once-returner" and "non-returner" are reinterpreted here for the bodhisattva, with "does not come here" playing on the non-returner's name.

• The arhat section plays on two etymologies of the word: the Tibetan □□□□□□□□□, "one who has destroyed the foe," echoed in the repeated "destroyed," and the Sanskrit arhat, "worthy," echoed in the repeated "worthy" (□□□). In "worthy to free" the text reads □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, "to explain"; this has been read as □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, "to free," which the context requires.

• The refrain throughout plays on the Indian etymology of arhat as "one who is worthy" (Skt. arhati), which the Tibetan renders with "worthy" (□□□) in each clause, alongside the Tibetan name "foe-destroyer." "The perishing collection" renders □□□□□□□□□ (Skt. satkāya), i.e. the view that takes the aggregates as a real self. The list of what beings are freed from is rendered as the Tibetan gives it; several items (for example, freeing from "the nonarising, the noncessation, and the nonformation of all dharmas" and from "the nondisintegration of form") are best understood as freeing beings from fixation on even these ultimate characteristics.

• Several verses use the verb □□□□□ ("unravel, untie"), which here has the sense of the prose's "free" (□□□□□), and is rendered "set free." In the verse on laziness, □□□□□ is read in the sense of conceptual thought (□□□□), matching the parallel verse on the śrāvakas. "The perishing collection" (Skt. satkāya) refers to the aggregates taken as a self. In the verse on teaching beings, "in no way does he give rise to affliction" renders the Tibetan as it stands; the parallel prose speaks instead of not mixing dharmas.

• The section on the śrāvaka plays on the word's etymology: Tibetan □□□□□□ ("hearer") renders Skt. śrāvaka, which can also be understood as "one who causes others to hear," that is, one who proclaims (□□□□□□), as the bodhisattva does here. "Gentle one" renders □□□□□ (Skt. sūrata or dānta). The final quotation continues into the next piece.

• "Trichiliocosm" renders □□□□□□□□□, the world system of a thousand million worlds. In the verse on the buddha fields, "those closed off" renders □□□□□ (literally "blocked, restricted"); it seems to contrast with "the most excellent" fields, but the exact sense is uncertain. The closing line opens the explanation of the bodhisattva as pratyekabuddha, which the next piece develops in terms of direct perception (pratyakṣa).

• □□□ is rendered "limit" throughout, as in "the limit of reality" (Skt. bhūtakoṭi), rather than "extreme," since the passage concerns the ultimate limit or end-point of beings and dharmas. The pratyekabuddha section plays on the Sanskrit: the bodhisattva is a pratyekabuddha because things are directly perceived (pratyakṣa) by him and because he comprehends conditionality (pratyaya).

• "Limit" renders the term otherwise glossed as "extreme" (anta), kept as "limit" for continuity with the preceding verses on the limit of beings and the limit of reality. As throughout this sūtra, the terms pratyekabuddha, "self-perfected buddha" (rang rdzogs sangs rgyas) and "solitary victor" are reinterpreted as designations of the bodhisattva who realizes these truths by himself, playing on "self" (rang). In the cycle of verses on the aggregates the Tibetan as it stands repeats "feeling" where the pattern leads one to expect "perception", and in each following cycle the "directly perceived" verse names the next aggregate (perception before formations, consciousness before formations' closing verse); this has been translated as written. "Another aggregate" in the first such verse may be a slip for "this aggregate", as in the

parallel verses, but is kept as written.
• "Hidden speech" renders ldem po ngag (Skt. saṃdhābhāṣya), intentional or allusive speech whose literal sense differs from its intent. "The eighth" (aṣṭamaka) is the candidate for stream-entry, counted as the eighth of the noble persons from the top. In the verse on the conditions (rkyen, pratyaya), the text plays on the term pratyekabuddha, glossed as one who has understood the conditions. In the verse on becoming, "perception of it as baneful" renders sdig pa can; the exact sense of the line is somewhat uncertain.
• The arhats' declarations are deliberately paradoxical statements of the kind the sūtra calls hidden speech; they are explained in what follows. "Ill will" renders brnag pa, whose sense here is uncertain. In the stream-enterers' verse, bsten pa ("relied on") is read as bstan pa ("taught"), which the parallel verses support. "Koṭis of niyutas" renders bye ba khrag khrig, a stock vast number.
• Mañjuśrī reinterprets the five deeds of immediate retribution (killing one's mother, father, or an arhat, splitting the Saṅgha, and drawing a Tathāgata's blood) as the destruction of ignorance, craving and so on; the last two are alluded to only by "split apart" and by the perception of the Tathāgata. "Utterly destroyed" for the father reads bcom btags as bcom. In "by the perception of the sun," nya ma is read as nyi ma ("sun"); the next passage suggests the sense "perception of day."
• The verses explain the arhats' paradoxical declarations of the previous passage, with "unbroken continuity" playing on the term for the deeds of immediate retribution (literally "without interval"). The line about "five fingers in space" is obscure; it is translated literally.
• The phrase rendered "speak without duplicity" (literally "speak non-dually") means that the buddhas' word is never two-sided or false, and it ties back to the tongue covering the trichiliocosm as a sign of truthful speech. Ānanda's remark that those lacking faith "will be brought to faith by those who have been won over" renders a terse clause (literally "by those who have come under the power"); it may instead mean those who have gained mastery.
• "My buddhafield is not one possessed of the five degenerations" follows the Tibetan as written, though Śākyamuni's field is traditionally described as degenerate; the sentence may be meant as a rhetorical contrast, and the reading is uncertain. "Because I declared no phenomenon at all" renders a terse clause that likely expresses the inexpressibility of all phenomena. "Grant me protection" renders a rare phrase (literally "bestow chab") whose exact sense is uncertain.
• The Buddha's promises to Māra are deliberately double-edged: on the surface they grant Māra's wish, but read in terms of emptiness they state that no being is ever truly established in awakening or moved from anything, since beings and phenomena are not ultimately found. The phrase rendered "go with an easy heart" is literally "go with a small heart," apparently meaning relieved and untroubled.
• These verses unpack, in terms of emptiness, the double-edged promises made to Māra in the previous passage; several stanzas play on the wording of those promises (for example "not given" and "nothing wrong"), and their terse phrasing makes some readings uncertain, notably the line rendered "It is not space, and it is not moved," the stanza on awakening as "not given," and the closing line of the stanza on giving away young women ("This is no illumination," perhaps meaning it is not taught or approved). The "five fires" are the ascetic practice of sitting among four fires under the sun.
• In the list of offerings the Tibetan reads "a hundred buddhas" followed by a garbled syllable in the last item; it has been read as "to a hundred buddhas" in line with the preceding items. The name of the world system, Lotus Towering Like Meru, is translated from the Tibetan, as its Sanskrit form could not be identified with confidence.
• The verb rendered "release" (Tibetan 'grel, "explain") in the two verses on freeing beings is read as 'grol, "release, untie," which the context plainly requires; the two spellings are easily

confused. The phrase rendered "a little boy" (khye'u gzhon nu thor bu) is uncertain; thor bu may instead refer to a topknot or to blemishes, but the sense of the simile is unaffected. In the verse on the wise ones of the past, the line "not having arrived, did not pass into nirvāṇa" is terse and could also be read "they neither arrived nor passed into nirvāṇa." "Veiled speech" renders ldem po'i ngag (Skt. saṃdhābhāṣā), intentional or indirect speech.

• The verb rendered "sets free" (Tibetan rnam par 'grel, literally "explains") is read as rnam par 'grol, "frees," as in the preceding passage; the two spellings are easily confused. "Beyond reproach" renders ma smad, whose sense in this line is uncertain. The "plantain trunk" (Skt. kadalīskandha) is the standard image of something with no solid core.

• Several bodhisattva names could not be identified with confidence and are translated by meaning: Smiling Serene Faculties (dgod pa dang bcas par dbang po dang ba), Dustless Intellect (rdul med blo gros), Devoted to Stūpas (mchod rten la mos pa), and Ever Longing (rtag tu 'dod). As in earlier passages, 'grel ("explain") in the verses of Smiling Serene Faculties is read as 'grol ("free, release"), which the context requires. "The perishable collection" ('jig tshogs, Skt. satkāya) refers to the aggregates mistakenly taken as a self.

• The bodhisattva names in this passage could not be identified with a Sanskrit form and are translated by meaning: Devoted to Garments (gos la mos pa), Giver of Food (kha zas gtong), Rightly Engaged in Compassion on Seeing Beings (sems can mthong na snying rje la yang dag par zhugs pa), and Wholly Abandoning Evil Friends (sdig pa'i bshes gnyen yongs su spangs pa). The phrase phyi phyir is taken as "turning away" in the first verse and as "hereafter" in "Hereafter they are Māra's due"; both readings are uncertain. In Wholly Abandoning Evil Friends' first verse, rnam 'grel ba ("explaining") is read as rnam 'grol ba, "frees," as elsewhere in this text.

• "Dispels the manifold fruits of karma" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, literally "dispelling various fruits"; "of karma" is supplied from context. The maiden's name □□□□□□ is given as Siṃhā (Lion), a reconstruction. "For the sake of enjoyment" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, which probably implies sensual gratification. The closing exception (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) refers to a woman's form taken on deliberately, as a miraculous display, by an advanced being.

• "Never be made to keep company with them" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, literally "may we not come to meet"; it apparently refers to being given to husbands. "We will not give up our resolve" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, whose exact sense is uncertain. The world realm and the tathāgata are rendered from their Tibetan meanings, since no Sanskrit forms could be identified with confidence. "Sisters" renders the address □□□□□□□□.

• The first line reads □□□□□□, evidently a slip for □□□□□□□ "woman", as translated. The line □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is terse; it may also mean that the childish are deluded about the wise. □□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□ "as I now". Mañjuśrī's statement that the Tathāgata had not set his mind on awakening before Mañjuśrī turned this discourse reflects the motif of Mañjuśrī as the one who first inspires the buddhas.

• "A hundred million" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□ (a hundred times a million). □□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□ "confess individually", a evident slip. The request that the Buddha explain "therefore" renders the connective □□□□□□□□, read as giving Ānanda's reason: the explanation will serve as a deterrent.

• Ānanda's remark that the irreversible bodhisattvas "are not themselves inclined toward the irreversible Saṅgha, nor counted among it" is a statement in the Tibetan, apparently an objection that the Buddha then answers; its precise point is unclear. Not perceiving even the mind set on awakening points to the realization that the mind itself is not apprehended.

• "Those of the Eighth Stage" renders □□□□□□□ (Skt. aṣṭamaka), the candidate for stream-entry, eighth counting back from the arhat. "Those Who Go from Family to Family" takes the abbreviated □□□□□□□□□ as the kulaṃkula, a stream-enterer reborn among a few families before

liberation; the abbreviation makes this identification somewhat tentative.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.